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IN BRIEF



Manipur musician killed in Delhi; 7 men arrested

NEW DELHI
Chongtham Vikram Singh, a musician from Manipur living in Delhi, died on Monday of injuries suffered in an alleged assault by a group on Sunday night. Delhi Police has arrested seven men in connection with the case. » **Page 12**

CM apologises after row over Bengal govt. ad

KOLKATA
West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari tendered an apology after an advertisement published by the government in Monday's newspapers depicting Goddess Durga with 11 hands instead of 10 sparked a row in the State. » **Page 5**

Delhi HC calls for audit of hostels; collapse toll hits 7

Building owner arrested, along with spouse and son; five MCD officials suspended; Delhi govt. mulling policy to govern buildings used for different purposes, including PG accommodations

Shrimansi Kaushik Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The death toll in the collapse of a building housing students in the Satya Niketan area rose to seven on Monday, even as the Delhi High Court expressed deep concern over the safety of students living in similar paying guest (PG) accommodations across the national capital.

It directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to inspect all PG hostels under its jurisdiction within a week.

The police arrested Hariram Gupta, 82, a retired Indian Air Force sergeant; his wife Urmila Gupta, 75; and their son Mahesh Gupta, 52. While the property was registered in Ms. Gupta's name, the men's PG accommodation was allegedly being run by her husband and son, the police said. A search is on for those operating it and the labour contractors that were carrying out repairs in the building's basement.

"Their role will also be examined in the case and accordingly action will be



Search on: Rescue operations under way at the site of the building collapse in New Delhi on Monday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

taken," said Amit Goel, Deputy Commissioner of Police, South West.

Five officials of the MCD – the civic body responsible for issuing PG licences and enforcing building norms – were suspended. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government is exploring a policy to govern buildings used for sev-

eral purposes, including PG accommodations.

Over the course of the 28-hour rescue operation, at least 12 people were brought to the AIIMS Trauma Centre while three were taken to the Safdarjung hospital for treatment. At AIIMS, six persons were brought dead while one person later died of injuries. At least three are said to be in critical condition. One person is stable while another was discharged on Sunday. The patients at Safdarjung are also stable.

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HC directs Assam govt. to pay ₹2L to kin of woman pushed into Bangladesh

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Gauhati High Court has directed the Assam government to pay ₹2 lakh as interim compensation to the husband of a Bengali-origin Muslim woman for pushing her into Bangladesh without an opportunity to challenge the order of a Foreigners Tribunal (FT).

The September 3 order was the first instance of any court imposing a cost on the State for pushing a person across the border by violating deportation rules.

A Division Bench of Justices Kalyan Rai Surana and Susmita Phukan Khaund passed the order after hearing a *habeas corpus* plea filed by Mujammel Hoque, the husband of Mumtaz Begum. It took serious exception to the way the FT in Nagaon handled Ms. Begum's case, observing that "malice in law" on the part of the tribunal appeared evident from the record.

The FT declared Ms. Begum a foreigner on May 30, when she appeared before it after an earlier HC direction to reconsider her case.

'Violation of procedure'
The court held that the procedure followed amounted to a "direct violation" of the standard operating procedure governing the expulsion of declared foreign nationals. Observing that the State prevented Ms. Begum from exercising her right to approach the HC against the FT's order, the Bench ordered the State to pay the petitioner (her husband).

"This palliative payment shall be in addition to and not in derogation of the petitioner's right to seek compensation before the civil court," the order read.

The court also impleaded the Ministry of External Affairs in the case and advised it to "make an endeavour to have the woman located in Bangladesh and expatriate her to India".

LPG booking interval for rural users cut to 25 days

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Union Petroleum Ministry on Monday reduced the interval between bookings of domestic liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) cylinders for rural consumers to 25 days, months after it had been increased to 45 days during the peak of the West Asia conflict.

This brings the interval between bookings for rural consumers on a par with urban consumers, for whom the period remains unchanged at 25 days.

In a letter to oil marketing companies, it cited "considerable reduction" in refill backlogs in the current supply situation among the reasons that prompted the move. LPG distributors' associations welcomed the move and said it will benefit them.

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Expedite work on new hostels: V-C to principals

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh on Monday asked college principals to review residential facilities for students, a day after a five-storey building housing college students collapsed in Satya Niketan.

Mr. Singh asked principals to expedite work on under-construction hostels and check the feasibility of constructing new ones so that such incidents do not recur, as per a university statement.

Meanwhile, several student groups held candle-light marches and protests at Satya Niketan demanding accountability from the government and from DU for not providing enough accommodation. On Sunday, the Opposition parties had also raised the issue, saying the lack of accommodation has forced students to live in overcrowded PG accommodations.



Students at a sit-in on Monday against the building collapse. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

The All India Students' Association and the National Students' Union of India staged demonstrations and called attention to the student housing crisis in the Capital.

The Krantikari Yuva Sangathan also voiced concern over the issue. The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad has demanded the resignation of Municipal Corporation of Delhi Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar over the tragedy.

Rising rents, ageing buildings and little room to breathe

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The collapse of a five-storey building housing students in Satya Niketan on Sunday has brought renewed scrutiny to the cramped living spaces and the compromises students make in the absence of affordable hostel accommodation.

In Delhi's student hubs, narrow lanes, ageing buildings pressed against each other, dangling electricity and cable wires, and rooms carved out wherever space permits have become a familiar reality.

For thousands of outstation students arriving in the Capital each year, these converted houses and tightly packed buildings are often the only affordable options, with a bed in a shared room costing anywhere from ₹12,000 to over ₹24,000 a month.

Near Delhi University's (DU) South Campus, Satya Niketan is a maze of small shops, property dealers,



Cramped setting: (Left) A multi-storey PG in a densely-packed neighbourhood of Malka Ganj near North Campus; many PGs in Jawahar Nagar are located in narrow, dimly-lit alleys. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

old buildings and newer constructions connected by uneven roads.

Unnayan, who moved to Delhi last month, lives about 100 metres from the collapsed building. He paid ₹14,000 this month for a bed on the fifth floor, where he no longer wants to live. "I chose the fifth floor and have to go up and down the stairs because the lower floors were more expensive. A bed on the second floor cost ₹17,000, and the first floor was even

more expensive," he said.

'Too afraid to stay'

With suitcases rolling behind them and bags slung over their shoulders, students streamed out of the congested lanes of Satya Niketan late into Sunday night. The collapse left many too frightened to spend another night in the neighbourhood they had called home.

For Anushriti, a native of Kanpur who had lived in Satya Niketan for nearly a



year, the fear was still raw. She left for a friend's home in Moti Bagh with little more than her phone.

"I have been in my nightdress for the past 24 hours with just a phone in my hand. I am stranded now... I can't go to my hometown, neither can I return to the PG," she said.

Her belongings remain on the fourth floor of her PG, but she has been too traumatised to return.

"I just need to go back there to get my things. I am

preparing myself mentally for the task," she added.

Common theme

At the other end of the city, in Jawahar Nagar near DU's North Campus, a narrow lane is choked with parked vehicles on both sides, leaving little room for pedestrians. Small shops are wedged between residential buildings while a web of electricity and cable wires hangs overhead.

Rakhi, a native of Haryana and a first-year BCom student at Daulat Ram College, pointed towards the ground-plus-five-storey building where she has been living for a month.

"I pay ₹17,000 for a bed and food, which is pathetic. Electricity is an additional cost," she said.

With no hostel available, Ms. Rakhi began looking for a paying guest (PG) accommodation when the academic session started.

"The rooms are very cramped. There is barely any ventilation. The rent is too high, but at least this is a room I can somehow sur-

vive in," she said.

A 10-minute scooter ride away, Nehru Nagar appears to narrow further with every turn. Buildings rise to five floors, their tiny entrances leading to uneven staircases and corridors punctuated by air conditioners. Riddhima (name changed), a final-year DU student, has spent four years in one such PG. "The place is not ideal to live in, with no ventilation or space even to walk, but this was the best I could find," she said.

Less than a kilometre away, Kamla Nagar is another student hub where almost every other building houses a PG. Tanya, a second-year DU student, pays ₹12,000 for a bed in a twin-sharing room, which has no window or ventilator, forcing her to keep the air conditioner running.

Space has become a premium commodity that students are paying for, even when it amounts to little more than a bed squeezed into an ageing building.

Protest against ongoing classes in building that PWD declared unsafe in 2016

Press Trust of India
FARIDABAD

Hundreds of students of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru College in Faridabad protested outside the institution on Monday against its dilapidated structure and lack of facilities.

According to students, the college building is nearly 50 years old and was flagged as unsafe by the Public Works Department (PWD) in 2016, but classes continue to be held in it.

The college, the city's largest government institution, has around 7,000 students, yet its building is in a deplorable state, students claimed.

"Plaster frequently falls from the walls, exposing the iron reinforcement bars; students are compelled to study under the constant shadow of fear," said a protester.

Acting principal and district higher education officer Ritika Gupta said the PWD has been asked to resume construction of a six-storey building that was stalled because of COVID-19 restrictions.

CM orders sealing of buildings with unauthorised fifth floor

Gupta directs inspection of Satya Niketan's PG facilities; Sood to head a panel to explore alternative housing for students; residents moved away from collapse site as authorities fear similar incidents

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday directed the immediate sealing of all buildings across the city with an unauthorised fifth floor.

She also directed the inspection of all paying guest (PG) accommodations in Satya Niketan after visiting the site in the south-west Delhi locality, where a five-storey structure housing a PG facility collapsed on Sunday.

The CM, along with Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood, later attended a meeting chaired by Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to explore alternative accommodation for students.

The L-G directed Mr. Sood to lead a committee to assess the feasibility of using unutilised and vacant buildings of the Delhi Development Authority and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi for students, as per a statement



On ground: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta with Cabinet Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa in Satya Niketan on Monday. PTI

from Lok Niwas.

Mayor Parvesh Wahi said that the North West zone has issued directions to inspect all buildings and seal those found violating norms. He said the MCD had fixed accountability by suspending five officials of the South Zone – Deputy Commissioner Rakesh Kumar, Senior Engineer Ranvir Singh, Executive Engineer (Building) Lalit Kumar Goel, Assistant Engineer (Building) Sunil Chauhan and Junior Engineer (Build-

ing) Ashish Kumar.

Three major incidents have occurred in the MCD's South Zone since May, all involving structures found to be violating building by-laws or licensing norms – an under-construction building collapse in Saidulajab that killed six people in May, a fire at a bed-and-breakfast facility in Malviya Nagar in June that killed 23 people, and Sunday's collapse.

"This is the first time that officials ranging from

the Deputy Commissioner to the Junior Engineer have been suspended with immediate effect in connection with an incident of this nature. This demonstrates that negligence at any level will not be tolerated," said Mr. Wahi.

'Seek info on buildings'

Meanwhile, the CM urged all MPs, MLAs and councilors in the national capital to collect information on illegal constructions in their respective areas and report those to the departments concerned. She said such illegal constructions would be promptly demolished.

While the agencies continued to remove rubble from the area, people were moved away from the site as the authorities feared the collapse of nearby buildings. As per documents accessed by *The Hindu*, show-cause notices have been issued to the owners of at least three buildings in the area since April over violations of the Unified Building Bye-Laws.

Oppn. mounts attack on govt. over proliferating PG facilities

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Congress held protests on Monday and hit out at the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Delhi over the Satya Niketan collapse.

AAP staged a protest near the site of the building collapse in Satya Niketan, demanding that the BJP government release a list of people who own paying guest (PG) accommodation in the area.

The party's Delhi unit president Saurabh Bhargava asked why action was not being taken against illegal PGs and whether "influential BJP leaders had financial interests" in such facilities.

Mr. Bhargava alleged that citizens have been claiming that several senior BJP leaders own properties in the area.

"The exploitation of students through expensive PG accommodations, and the MCD's failure to act against it, is linked to the fact that influential leaders have invested heavily in properties there," he said.

Mr. Bhargava added, "The names of influential



AAP members protesting near the collapse site on Monday. ANI

BJP leaders whose money is invested here must be made public."

Mr. Bhargava also said the Centre must build hostels for students.

"Until hostels are constructed and allotted to students, the government should pay their PG fees," he said.

'Justice for victims'

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav staged a sit-in at the collapse site, demanding justice for those injured and the families of those killed.

Mr. Yadav questioned who had permitted repairs in the basement of the 50-year-old, five-storey building without adequate safety measures after it was

flooded and alleged administrative negligence and corruption.

"The MCD Commissioner should resign, taking responsibility for the collapse. Such mishaps keep happening due to corruption in the civic body," Mr. Yadav said.

Govt. responds

Responding to the Opposition's allegations, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood said, "We are concerned about the safety of the children and about fixing the rotten system that the 'A-team' and 'B-team' have built up within this administration over the last 27 years. The focus must be on what action needs to be taken."

A mole on chest, a scar on knee: how families identified bodies of their sons

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A mole on the chest helped Puspaha Jhajj identify the body of her 19-year-old son, Arpit, at the AIIMS Trauma Centre on Monday, a day after the paying guest (PG) accommodation where he stayed collapsed in south-west Delhi's Satya Niketan.

Arpit had returned to Delhi from his native Devas in Madhya Pradesh on Sunday morning after spending Raksha Bandhan with family.

"We put him on the train to Delhi on Saturday night. He called me after reaching his room around 8 a.m. He then video-called around 11-11.30 a.m. Who would have known that was the last time we would speak?" Ms. Jhajj said.

She, her husband Bhupendra, and two other family members reached AIIMS around midnight but



spent hours without clarity about Arpit's whereabouts.

"They kept telling us Arpit was not here [AIIMS] and made us wait through the night," Ms. Jhajj said. It was only around noon on Monday that they were allowed to see an unidentified body.

"His face was completely distorted; his left cheek was heavily injured. The only way I could identify him was the big mole on his chest," she said, ad-

ding, "What will I do with the body now? My son is gone. The future we imagined is gone."

PUSHPA JHAJJ
Mother of deceased Arpit

'Difficult to recognise'

For 18-year-old Akshat Singh Yadav's family, an old knee injury became the unlikely clue that helped identify him.

His uncle, Biren Kumar Yadav, said Akshat's face was so badly injured that it was very difficult to recognise him.

A childhood injury and the stitches left behind after an operation eventually confirmed his identity.

"When he was a child, he fell and injured his knee. I took him to the hospital and he underwent an operation. The stitches near his knee became an identifying mark as his face was completely unrecognisable," Mr. Biren said, tearing up.

A long wait

Akshat's family had been at the hospital since 4 a.m. and received his body around 2 p.m. "His mother had asked him not to go and stay a little longer. But he said he had to leave for classes. Now he is no more," Mr. Biren said.

Akshat had lived on the first floor of the PG for a year and had returned to Delhi only two days earlier from his home in Madhya Pradesh. His body was recovered around 3 a.m. during the search operation.

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

A women's PG facility in Satya Niketan, located 300 metres from the five-storey structure that collapsed the previous day, on Monday asked all occupants to vacate their rooms immediately.

'Sealing imminent'

A student said they were told that the hostel could be sealed any time and that the facility would operate only as long as supplies last.

Of the estimated 40 occupants, only 22 currently remain in the facility. The rest left for their hometowns soon after the incident, said a student.

"My parents just left after helping me with the admission and lodging. They are now worried and want to take me away. But it will take them two days to arrive by train. What will I do until then?" said Himanshi



A civil defence volunteer with books pulled out of the rubble of the five-storey structure in Satya Niketan that collapsed on Sunday. ANI

Aggarwal, who hails from Assam.

Air of uncertainty

Thousands of outstation students who paid rent and security deposits in advance at PG facilities in the south-west Delhi locality are facing uncertainty after Sunday's incident, with the

authorities announcing a sealing drive against unauthorised structures.

'University apathetic'

"The college is still open. The administration has not shown any interest in understanding our situation. How will we attend classes if we go back to our home-

towns?" added Ms. Aggarwal, a Maitreyi College student.

Prajakta, a first-year student, said, "We have not been given an exact date. The warden has only asked us to vacate rooms as soon as possible".

'Paid security, rent'

"I rented a ₹16,000 twin-occupancy room. I paid two months' rent as a security deposit and the current month's rent in advance. In all, I have already paid ₹48,000," added Ms. Prajakta.

The women's PG, which shares the name 'Hostel Daze' with the facility in the collapsed building, is also located in a five-storey structure.

There are four rooms on each floor except the ground floor, which has three. For now, students have packed their essential belongings and made arrangements to stay with friends or relatives.

INBRIEF



Sanjay Agrawal sworn in as Rajasthan HC Chief Justice

Justice Sanjay Kumar Agrawal was sworn in as the 44th Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court at a ceremony held at Lok Bhavan in Jaipur on Monday. Governor Haribhau Bagade administered the oath of office in the presence of Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma, his Cabinet colleagues, judges and administrative officials. The Union government notified Justice Agrawal's elevation as the Chief Justice and appointment in Rajasthan following a recommendation by the Supreme Court Collegium. He was first appointed as an additional judge of the Chhattisgarh High Court in September 2013.

HC sets aside arrest warrant against TMC's Mahua Moitra

The Calcutta High Court on Monday set aside an arrest warrant issued against TMC MP Mahua Moitra by a Krishnanagar court, and ordered transfer of the case against her over alleged hate speech to the special MP/MLA court at Bidhannagar here. Ms. Moitra, in a petition before the High Court, had challenged the legality of the arrest warrant issued against her by the Krishnanagar court. The High Court had on August 24 stayed the arrest warrant, which was issued by the third judicial magistrate at Krishnanagar due to Ms. Moitra's alleged non-compliance with directions to appear before it.

‘Conduct worthy of derision’: HC pulls up District Magistrate over NSA detention of student

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Allahabad High Court has come down heavily on Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam, who had issued the order to detain a 25-year-old Delhi University law student under the National Security Act (NSA) over a workers' protest in Noida in April this year. In a detailed order released on Monday, the court observed that Ms. Roopam “desired to make an example” out of the petitioner. A Bench of Justices Atul Sreedharan and Achal Sachdev had on September 2 quashed the NSA detention of Akriti Chaudhary, who had spent nearly five months in custody. The Bench had allowed Ms. Chaudhary's habeas corpus petition and ordered her immediate re-



Gautam Buddha Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam

lease, unless she was required in another case. The court flagged discrepancies in the arrest notice and termed the State's version a “concocted story”.

‘Guilty of violating oath’ Pulling up the District Magistrate, the Bench noted, “In this case, the conduct of the District Magistrate, who passed the impugned order, is worthy of derision.” The court observed that the District Magistrate “desired to set an exam-

ple” out of the petitioner and deter others from exercising their right to freedom of speech and expression in public spaces in support of workers. It added that Ms. Roopam is “guilty of violating her oath of allegiance, making this a fit case for the imposition of compensation to the petitioner”. The court directed that Ms. Chaudhary be paid compensation of ₹5 lakh and that the amount be recovered from the salary of the District Magistrate, who passed the order of detention “without application of mind”, and “all such other officers who may have been responsible, right down to the Station House Officer” of the police station, who had prepared the initial report warranting the detention of the petitioner under the provisions of the NSA.

Baiga children deaths: panel questions delay in response

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Members of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Social Justice and Empowerment questioned the government over its response to the deaths of Baiga tribe children in Madhya Pradesh's Balaghat district, asking why there were no clear answers on the cause of the deaths several months after the first cases were reported. The panel met representatives of the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, the Ministry of Jal Shakti, and the Department of Telecommunications to review the implementation of the Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan.

77 days and counting: Haryana teachers seek job regularisation

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM

Guest teachers in Haryana's government schools have intensified their agitation seeking regularisation of services, with their protest in Kurukshetra entering its 77th day on Monday. The teachers are demanding implementation of the State government's regularisation policies framed in 2014, citing recent judgments of the Supreme Court and the Punjab and Haryana High Court which, they say, have strengthened their claim for regularisation. The teachers have been staging the protest outside the Secretariat in Kurukshetra, which is the home city of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini. Two teachers sit on 24-hour rotation every day, according to the Rajkiya Anubandhit Ad-

hyapak Sangh, which is spearheading the protest. “We have won the case in the High Court as well as the Supreme Court. As far as I understand, the government has no legal option left,” Dinesh Yadav, State president of the association, told *The Hindu*. The government, however, has not yet initiated the process of regularisation. Mr. Yadav said a delegation of teachers had met the Education Minister, the Additional Chief Secretary and other senior officials, but no concrete assurance has been given so far. Bhupinder Singh, State general secretary of the association, said around 12,000 guest teachers are working on a contractual basis against sanctioned posts in government schools, and that nearly 55% of them are women. The teachers, appointed



Guest teachers protesting outside the Secretariat in Kurukshetra, the home city of Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

between 2005 and 2008, are working as Junior Basic Teachers, Trained Graduate Teachers, and Post Graduate Teachers.

Two policies At the centre of the dispute are two regularisation policies – a three-year policy and a 10-year policy – framed during the Congress regime in 2014. According to the association, the teachers had fulfilled

and also asked the Diamond Harbour MP to co-operate in the investigation. Appearing for Mr. Banerjee, senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, told the court that seven out of 16 FIRs against Mr. Banerjee has been filed by his unsuccessful opponent in the general election, Abhijit Das.

‘Akin to Suwendu case’ Mr. Sankaranarayanan submitted that Mr. Banerjee was facing a situation similar to that considered by the High Court in proceedings concerning Mr. Adhikari. “In Suwendu Adhikari's case, we have the exact same prayer. In our earlier plea your Lordship granted us relief in May and June. After those two orders, these FIRs were filed, exactly like in Mr. Adhikari's case, trying to circumvent the protection we have,” he submitted.

Vijay's broadside at DMK sparks uproar in Tamil Nadu Assembly

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Assembly was in uproar on Monday after Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay launched a scathing attack on the DMK and its leaders, accusing them of corruption and referring to the Sarkaria Commission report of the 1970s, the Veeranam “scandal”, and the alleged collection of “party funds” by what he called the “Karrur” gang.

Last week, Mr. Vijay had said he would make his reply and warned the DMK members not to “run away”.

Slogans raised DMK MLAs, who remained silent until 9.56 a.m. when the Chief Minister began his reply, started raising slogans first and displaying pamphlets later. They surrounded the



Chief Minister Vijay speaking in the Assembly on Monday. YOUTUBE/@TAMILNADUASSEMBLY

Speaker and even resorted to a sit-in after Mr. Vijay departed from his prepared speech, raised his voice, and targeted the DMK, case by case, accusing its leaders of nepotism. He further cited songs of AIADMK founder and former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran (MGR) and the words of late Tamil poet Kannadasan to attack the DMK.

Meanwhile, State government sources said the huge cost of 12 years' arrears and the fact that the guest teachers were recruited on the basis of village-level merit, rather than through Statewide competitive examinations, were preventing their regularisation despite the court orders. The protesting teachers are scheduled to meet government representatives for talks on Tuesday. A larger meeting involving several groups, including the Samyukt Kisan Morchha and municipal bodies, has also been planned for September 13, Mr. Yadav said.

Shinde suspends Sena leader arrested over attack on medical staff

Sena chief says such incidents would not be tolerated; police on lookout for remaining accused; second such ‘assault’ by a Sena leader since July 6

Yohaán Varghese
MUMBAI

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister and Shiv Sena chief Eknath Shinde on Monday suspended the party's Palghar city chief Rahul Gharat following the latter's arrest over the alleged assault on employees of a private hospital by Shiv Sena workers a day earlier. Mr. Shinde said such incidents would not be tolerated and warned of strict action against anyone found responsible.

Inspector Kishor Mahanubhav of the Palghar police station said Mr. Gharat was produced before a local magistrate, who remanded him to police custody for a day.

This is the second such incident of assault by Sena leaders in the recent past. Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre was arrested for allegedly assaulting doctors at a Thane hospital on July 6.

A wider probe into the Palghar attack was under way even as the police re-



Maharashtra Deputy CM and Shiv Sena chief Eknath Shinde warned of strict action against anyone found responsible. FILE PHOTO

main on the lookout for the remaining accused persons, the officer said.

According to the police, five ‘govindas’ who were a part of a Shiv Sena Dahi Handi celebrations in Palghar were admitted to Relief Hospital in Palghar.

“The bill for the treatment of the govindas came to ₹19,000. Seventeen Sena members came to the hospital and had already paid ₹10,000; the remaining amount was yet to be paid. One of the govindas, aged 19, wanted to go home in Virar. But the doctor said he wanted to keep him for 24-hour

observation,” Mr. Mahanubhav said. The officer added that the party members refused to pay the remaining amount until the 19-year-old was released, following which an argument broke out and the party workers assaulted the staff.

CCTV footage Mr. Gharat, who was part of the group, allegedly slapped a staff member. CCTV footage from the hospital purportedly shows one person slapping a receptionist. The police have registered an FIR against 17 individuals.

BJP to begin 4-day Statewide stir in Jharkhand over cases against students from today

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Jharkhand has finalised preparations for a Statewide agitation starting September 8 to demand the withdrawal of cases filed by the police against students protesting against alleged irregularities in recruitment exams, including Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

Responsibility assigned The party has assigned responsibilities to workers and asked prominent leaders to join the protests in their respective areas.

State general secretary Amar Kumar Bauri on Monday said that a four-day agitation, protests and the gherao of Deputy Commissioner and Superintendent of Police offices will be conducted at 24 district headquarters on a scheduled basis from September 8 to 11.

“Following the directives of State party president, specific leaders have been entrusted with the responsibility of leading the movement in different



Police dispersing student protesters attempting to breach barricades during an Assembly march in Ranchi. FILE PHOTO

districts,” Mr. Bauri said.

As per the schedule prepared, Mr. Sahu will be in Ranchi on September 8, Seraikela on September 9, and Khunti on September 11. Similarly, Leader of the Opposition Babulal Marandi will be in Dumka on September 8, Pakur on September 9, Sahibganj on September 10, and Godda on September 11.

Former Chief Minister Raghubar Das will be in Hazaribagh on September 8, Dhanbad on September 10, and Lohardaga on September 11.

Also, former Chief Minister Madhu Koda will be in Jamshedpur on September 8, Bokaro on September 9, and Ramgarh on September 11, whereas former national president of the ST Morchha, Samir

Oraon, will be in Simdega on September 9, Gumla and Chaibasa on September 10, and Giridih on September 11.

Union Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth will be in Garhwa on September 8, and former State president Ravindra Rai will be in Chatra on September 10 and Jamtara on September 11.

Ultimatum issued A BJP delegation had recently issued an ultimatum to the State government, conveyed through the Chief Secretary, demanding the withdrawal of cases registered against students, but the State government remained silent on the matter. Following this, the BJP decided on the Statewide agitation.

Cong. leaders on their way to Saharanpur detained for hours

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Police on Monday detained several Congress leaders, including State unit president Ajay Rai, in Lucknow while on their way to Saharanpur following the demolition of a century-old mosque in the Saharanpur Collectorate complex two days earlier following a court order. The Congress leaders were released hours later in the evening.

On Sunday, Mr. Rai had announced that a fact-finding delegation would visit Saharanpur to assess the situation.

Alleging that the administration is working on the directions of the Bharatiya Janata Party government to silence the Opposition, Mr. Rai said, “Following the bulldozing of the mosque, we were going to take stock of the situation in Saharanpur, but we were detained by the police as soon as we left the party office. This authoritarian action is clear evidence of the fact that the government is afraid of the Congress party's democratic pushback. This is a struggle against injustice and dictatorship.”

In Saharanpur, a Samajwadi Party delegation submitted a petition to the district authorities addressed to the President of India seeking action against officers responsible for the demolition. Opposition leaders earlier questioned the “hurried demolition” of the mosque just three days after a district court ruling.

Meanwhile, an Archaeological Survey of India team began examining the well found during the removal of debris on Sunday, triggering a debate over its historical significance. Congress MP Imran Masood said the well was part of the mosque and was used in earlier times to meet the requirement of water for wuzu (ablution) before prayers.

BJP allows Gen Z to express themselves freely: Samik

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya on Monday said his party does not believe in treating Gen Z as a separate group and allows young people the freedom to express themselves. Addressing a press conference at the BJP office here, Mr. Bhattacharya said the party did not believe in imposing its diktat on the younger generation or isolating them as a separate group.

His comments came against the backdrop of the BJP's efforts to consider Gen Z as an important constituency ahead of the civic polls.

Mr. Bhattacharya, a Rajya Sabha MP, also said people should have the freedom to decide what they want to eat and should not be subjected to restrictions based on cultural or religious considerations.

"If someone wants to relish and savour fish or mutton, say on Nabami, what is the harm?" he said.

His comments came after some Hindu outfit leaders called upon Bengali Hindus to avoid non-vegetarian food during Navratri.

CM apologises after Bengal govt. advertisement depicts Goddess Durga with 11 hands

BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya downplays issue, says extra hand only makes Durga 'stronger'; Suwendu says govt. will be careful in future; Opposition mounts attack over 'distortion'

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday apologised to the people of the State after the State government published an advertisement in newspapers depicting Goddess Durga with 11 hands instead of 10.

"As the CM of West Bengal, I apologise for the error. The people responsible have received a stern warning. In future, the government will be careful," Mr. Adhikari said at a Durga Puja coordination meeting on Monday evening.

The advertisement published in several West Bengal newspapers on Monday sparked a major debate on social media and in political circles.

As Opposition leaders came down heavily on the "distortion" of the deity, BJP State president Samik Bhattacharya sought to downplay the issue, saying



Women participating in a procession to demand traditional Durga Puja celebrations, in Kolkata on Sunday. PTI

that the extra hand only makes Durga "stronger".

"This only makes Maa Durga stronger," Mr. Bhattacharya said. He also added that the slip-up was a gross error by the advertising agency and said the mistake would be rectified and that it should not be politicised.

The Trinamool Congress (TMC) and Communist Party of India (Marxist) criticised the State government. The TMC official social media page said the constant mishandling of Maa Durga and Bengali culture is an insult. "A government that claims to speak for Bengal seems increasingly discon-

nected from Bengali culture, traditions, and the festivals that define Bengal's identity," the party added.

TMC MLA Madan Mitra also criticised the advertisement and said as a Bengali he could not accept the distortion.

'Resounding slap' CPI(M) leader Shatarup Ghosh also posted a picture of the advertisement on his social media and said that it is a "brilliant" ad by the State government.

"The gods had armed her with ten hands to slay the Asura (demon). The BJP government, however, has bestowed an extra hand upon the Goddess – specifically to deliver a resounding slap to anyone who might issue a decree forcing Bengalis to eat vegetarian food during the Puja," Mr. Ghosh wrote.

Netizens took to social media to criticise the advertisement and called it "dis-respect" of Bengali tradition and culture.

T.N. bypolls: all eyes on whether TVK will field ex-AIADMK MLAs

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

With the Election Commission (EC) notifying the byelection schedule for two out of the seven vacant Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu, the question on everyone's mind is whether the AIADMK MLAs who had resigned from Madurantakam and Dharapuram (both reserved seats) and joined the ruling TVK would get an opportunity to contest

the bypolls.

Soon after the formation of the TVK-led government, 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs voted in favour of the motion of confidence moved by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay.

Subsequently, six AIADMK MLAs resigned and joined the TVK. However, the losing candidates filed election pleas challenging the results in five constituencies. As per law, the EC cannot notify bypolls in these seats.

Consequently, the EC announced bypolls only to Madurantakam and Dharapuram. P. Sathyabama, who resigned as Dharapuram MLA, said she will seek a ticket for the bypoll.

"However, the party leadership will take the final call," she added.

Maragatham Kumaravel, who resigned as Madurantakam MLA, declined to comment. Former Minister R.B. Udhayakumar of the AIADMK said the party will definitely contest the polls.



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in



Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Alam Din S/O Mohd Sadiq R/O Bakoui Tehsil District Rajouri is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No95/1999 U/S 325/34 RPC of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Alam Din
S/O : Mohd Sadiq
Address : Bakoui Tehsil District Rajouri
Age : 55-60 years

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912433778
6. P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP/J- 9684/26, Sep 07 2026



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0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in



Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Hitler Kumar S/O Chhote Lal R/O Sector No. 04, Trikuta Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 04/2019 U/S 457/380 RPC of P/S Channi Himmat, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/ Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Hitler Kumar
S/O : Chhote Lal
Address : Sector No. 04, Trikuta Nagar, Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912433778
6. P/S Channi Himmat : 0191-2465164

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP/J- 9683/26, Sep 07 2026



THE HINDU

DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.



GOVERNMENT OF TAMILNADU
WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT
PENNAIYAR BASIN CIRCLE, TIRUVANNAMALAI – 606 603.



e-Tender Notice No. 01 / PBC / TVMALAI / 2026 / Dated : 07.09.2026
Lumpsum Contract (Two Cover System)

For and on behalf of the Governor of Tamil Nadu, the Superintending Engineer, WRD, Pennaiyar Basin Circle, Tiruvannamalai – 3, invites ONLINE tenders under "Two Cover System" through online for the under mentioned work from the eligible tenderers as prescribed in the website.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Approximate Value put to Tender (including GST) Rs. in Lakh	Last date and time of submission of Tender (as per Server Clock)	Date and time of Tender opening (as per Server Clock)	Period of Completion (including Rainy Season)
1.	Comprehensive Flood Protection works for Flood Bank Formation and Construction of Head Regulators in North Malattar River in Villupuram Taluk and District.	Rs. 2912.00	13.10.2026 upto 15.00 Hrs.	14.10.2026 at 15.30 Hrs.	12 Months

The tender document and other details will be available in the website <https://tntenders.gov.in> to enable the tenderers to view and download the e-tender document thru' online at free of cost and submission of Tenders shall be done only through online.

NOTE :

i) It is the responsibility of the tenderer to check any Corrigendum issued for any correction or modification uploaded subsequently in website, the same shall be taken into account while submitting tender.

ii) The Tender Authority does not take any responsibility for the delay/non-submission of tender/non-reconciliation of online payment caused due to non-availability of internet connection, network traffic/holidays or any other reasons.

iii) Tender may be cancelled at any stage by competent authority.

iv) **Cost of EMD will be paid through online mode only.**

Superintending Engineer, WRD.,
Pennaiyar Basin Circle, Tiruvannamalai – 3.

DIPR/ 2764 /Tender/2026



Patna Municipal Corporatio
NIT No. 28/CME/PMC/2026
Tender Notice



Patna Municipal Corporation invites online bids through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in for following works from the bidders fulfilling eligibility criteria's.

SL. No.	Name of Work	Cost of Tender (Non-Refundable) (Paid Through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)	EMD (Paid Through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
1	Request For Proposal Through E-Procurement From Reputed Entities Request For Proposal (Rfp) For Selection Of An Event Management Agency (EMA) For Conceptualizing, Curating & Executing The Cultural Event At Patliputra Mahotsav – 2026 In Patna, Bihar.	Rs. 11,800/-	Rs 30,00,000/- (Rupees Thirty lakh only) (Refundable).

Key Dates:

Start of online bid/downloading of bid documents :05-09-2026, 11:00
Pre-bid Meeting :12-09-2026 11:00 hrs
Last date of submission of Pre-bid Query :11.09.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.
Last date of Online Bid Submission :21-09-2026, 15:00 hrs.
Technical Bid Opening date :22-09-2026 at 11:00 hrs
The preferred Company/ agency would be selected through bidding process based on evaluation of bid proposal. The bidders are expected to submit their proposal in accordance with the instruction provided in the RFP. Detailed Request for Proposal (RFP) incorporating instructions for submission of bid and other relevant information's will be available on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and www.pmc.bihar.gov.in from bid start date. Amendment/Corrigendum/ any information to NIT, if any would be published on website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in only.

Patna Municipal Corporation
Mauriya Lok Complex,Buddha Marg, Patna, Bihar, 800 001
www.pmc.bihar.gov.in
Email-id-pmcpdrda@gmail.com/cmepmcpdrda01@gmail.com
M: +91 9431649493
PR- 011138 (B & C) 2026-27

Chief Municipal Engineer
Patna Municipal Corporation
नरो की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।



GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
MUNICIPAL ADMINISTRATION AND WATER SUPPLY DEPARTMENT
Directorate of Municipal Administration, Chennai-28. Tel: 044-29864447

Notice for Inviting Tender (NIT)
(Roc.No.616/2026/UPA, Date:02.09.2026)

1. Tenders are invited from eligible bidders for engaging a Manpower Outsourcing Agency for the hiring of one State Mission Manager and 83 City Mission Managers.

2. The tender value from is Rs.2313.60 lakhs.

3. The details of tender can be obtained from web portal: <https://tntenders.gov.in>

4. The tender document can be downloaded from 10.09.2026 to 14.10.2026 through the E-tendering Website <https://tntenders.gov.in>

5. Pre-Bid meeting will be held on 23.09.2026 at 3.00 P.M at the Directorate of Municipal Administration office.

6. The last date for uploading / submission of filled up tender is up to 3.00 P.M on 14.10.2026.

7. The tenders will be opened through online at 3.30 P.M on 14.10.2026 at the Directorate of Municipal Administration office.

8. The value of tender of Earnest Money Deposit and the eligibility of bidders can be had from tender document.

CHIEF ENGINEER,
CHENNAI – 28

DIPR/2767/TENDER/2026



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in



Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Raj Bhadur S/O Dil Bhadur R/O Dharti Bara Nepal A/P Sector A Trikuta Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. FIR No. 36/2003 U/S 457/380 RPC of P/S Channi Himmat, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Raj Bhadur
S/O : Dil Bhadur
Address : Dharti Bara Nepal
A/P : Sector A Trikuta Nagar, Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912433778
6. P/S Channi Himmat : 0191-2465164

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP/J- 9682/26, Sep 07 2026



Bihar Medical Services & Infrastructure
BMSICL Corporation Limited, Patna
(A Govt. of Bihar Undertaking)
2nd & 3rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS Campus, Sheikhpura, Patna, Bihar
Phone: +91 612 2283287, Fax: - +91 612 2283289



NOTICE
Investor Consultation Workshop Notification
Operation, Maintenance and Management of Brownfield Medical Colleges and Hospitals on Public Private Partnership Mode in Bihar.

Bihar Medical Services & Infrastructure Corporation Limited, Government of Bihar proposes to explore Public Private Partnership (PPP) models for establishment, development, operation and management of Brownfield Medical Colleges and Hospitals in the State. The proposed initiative aims to leverage private sector investment, expertise and operational efficiency to strengthen medical education and healthcare infrastructure.

An Investor Consultation Workshop is proposed for the organisations who submitted their Expression of Interest in response against Request for Expression of Interest (REoi) uploaded on BMSICL site. (<http://bmsicl.gov.in>)

The workshop will seek participants' views and recommendations on suitable PPP structures, project viability, risk allocation, regulatory requirements, and the proposed implementation framework.

Workshop Details

Date: 15.09.2026 Time: 11:30 AM
Venue: Chanakya Hotel, Bir Chand Patel Marg, opposite Rabindra Bhawan, R-Block, Patna, Bihar – 800001

Eligible organisations are requested to nominate up to two representative(s) for participation in the workshop and submit their nomination in the prescribed format including name, designation, organisation name, mobile number and email address of the nominated participant(s) uploaded on BMSICL site. (<http://bmsicl.gov.in>)

Confirmation of participation may be sent by email to ppmchbmsicl@gmail.com latest by 14.09.2026 until 1:00 PM.

The consultation is non-binding in nature and is intended solely for obtaining market feedback and stakeholder input. It shall not be construed as an invitation to bid, tender notice, or commitment on the part of the Government of Bihar or any of its agencies to proceed with any specific procurement process. The Government reserves the right to modify, defer, cancel, or proceed with the proposed initiative at its discretion.

For any query, please contact -9836687770, during office hours on working days.

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

Managing Director
BMSICL Patna

PR- 011312 (B & C) 2026-27

नरो से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।



M.P. STATE ELECTRONICS DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LTD.
State IT Centre, 47-A, Arera Hills, Bhopal-462011 (M.P.)
www.mpsedc.mp.gov.in, Ph. No.: 0755-2518300, marketing@mpsedc.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (NIT)/EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)

MPSEDC invites online proposals for following bids on MP Tender :-

S.No.	Tender No./EOI	NIT
1.	MPSEDC/ MKT/2026/707	RFP for Implementation of Web-Based Online Accounting Software at M.P. State Co-Operative Marketing Federation Ltd. (Second Call)
2.	MPSEDC/AVGC-XR/ CoE/EOI/2026/708	EOI for Establishment and Operation of the AVGC-XR CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE in Madhya Pradesh
3.	MPSEDC/AVGC-XR/ Labs/EOI/2026/709	EOI for Identification of Interested Organizations/Operational Partners for Establishment and Operation of AVGC-XR Training Labs in Government Colleges of Madhya Pradesh

For detailed scope of work, terms and conditions please refer to the respective bid/EOI document available on MP Tender Portal (www.mptenders.gov.in).
M.P. Madhyam/127870/2026

CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER



The plans for expansion of the Karnataka Cabinet has been put on the backburner for now, as per sources. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Congress in no hurry to fill vacant posts in Karnataka Cabinet

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The upcoming celebrations to mark the completion of 100 days in office by the Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar-led Congress government, followed by the three-day Special Session of the legislature, are expected to delay the party's decision to fill the two vacant posts in the Cabinet.

With the Chief Minister busy preparing for the 100 days bash in the second week of September and for the legislature session convened to discuss drought and the Kasturirangan report in the third week of September, the filling of the two posts has been put on the back burner for now, sources said.

Also, Cabinet appointments – if done – could come along with certain additions to the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee headed by B.K. Hariprasad, which is yet to witness some key additions.

“Any move to fill the va-

cancies would have to address the women, the Kuruba and Valmiki angle, besides the question of accommodating former Minister and Vokkaliga legislator from Vijayanagar, M. Krishnappa,” sources said.

The Central leadership has to pave the way for a solution, and it would happen when the high command decides, sources added. While one post was kept vacant in light of the last-minute confusion over A.V. Gayatri Shanthegowda, MLC, the other has fallen vacant after B. Nagen-dra resigned after sustained demand by the Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party and Janata Dal (Secular) over the multi-crore Valmiki Corporation scam.

Meanwhile, another source said: “After the smooth and powerful launch of Mr. Shivakumar as Chief Minister, the developments around Cabinet expansion went off steam. The party is also worried that it could stir up the hornet’s nest once again.”

Satheesan-Rahul meet fuels talk over next KPCC chief

Incumbent president Sunny Joseph has expressed his desire to step down from the post; Kodikunnil Suresh, Benny Behanan, Shafi Parambil are among the front-runners for the post

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan’s closed-door meeting with Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, in New Delhi on Monday assumed political significance at a time when the Congress high command is yet to settle the increasingly contentious question of the next Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president.

The All India Congress Committee (AICC) has been reportedly searching for a leader to replace Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph as KPCC president.

The Congress’s Facebook post said that Mr.



Succession talk: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi with Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

Satheesan had met with Mr. Gandhi to discuss “key party matters and governance priorities.”

However, the meeting took place at a time when Mr. Joseph had repeatedly expressed his desire to opt out of the key organisational responsibility. Several

names have figured in the discussions, with Kodikunnil Suresh, a 10-time Congress MP; Benny Behanan, Shafi Parambil, both MPs; and Mathew Kuzhalsadan, MLA, among the front-runners.

The AICC had previously insisted that Congress

workers elected to public office or holding other posts could not double up as PCC presidents. Even as the AICC is juggling names, Mr. Suresh, who is also a Congress Working Committee (CWC) member, has been one of the most persistent claimants to the post, highlighting his long experience and seniority in the organisation.

Suresh’s claim

On Monday, Mr. Suresh told presspersons in New Delhi that being an MP or MLA did not preclude Congress workers from holding the post of PCC president. He pointed out that the AICC had nominated MPs and MLAs in Tamil Nadu, Assam, and Punjab recently.

Revanth seeks KCR apology over BRS MLC’s remarks; BJP stages walkout

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has demanded that Leader of the Opposition K. Chandrashekhar Rao apologise to the institution of the Speaker and the people for Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) MLC Tata Madhu’s remarks, including the alleged objectionable language used against Speaker G. Prasad

Kumar. Speaking in the Assembly on Monday, the Chief Minister alleged that the BRS had a long history of insulting Dalits. He mentioned that the BRS chief had promised to make a Dalit the first Chief Minister of Telangana, but did not do so.

Mr. Reddy stated he had never heard such objectionable language against a Dalit leader and the institution of the Speaker anywh-

ere since he had been a member of different Houses except Rajya Sabha.

Earlier, Ministers D. Sridhar Babu, A. Laxman Kumar, Ponnampalabathi, G. Vivek and D. Seethakka condemned the BRS Council member’s alleged remarks against the Speaker

Floor Leader of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) A. Maheshwar Reddy condemned the BRS member’s

remarks and demanded that Mr. Rao apologise.

Meanwhile, the BJP members staged a walkout after Payal Shankar demanded action against the BRS member’s remarks against the Speaker. He requested the Speaker to check the genuineness of the video footage containing the member’s reported remarks since AI-morphed and fake videos were damaging individuals.

INBRIEF



Mammootty turns 75; wishes pour in from leaders, fans

Veteran actor Mammootty turned 75 on Monday. Fans reached his residence in Kochi on Sunday night and distributed cakes even as the actor thanked them through a video call from Chennai. On his birthday, the actor took to social media to announce the first-look poster of his new movie *Mela*. In his greetings, Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said “the pride of Malayalam” had created magic on the screen over the last five decades. Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan said Mammootty has explored the immense possibilities of acting through his roles.

Satheesan writes to Centre, calls for NH safety review

Close on the heels of the accident at Kaipamangalam in Thrissur that claimed the lives of eight students, Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan has written to Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari, seeking a comprehensive review of safety measures on the national highways in the State. The letter urged the Union Minister to direct the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to conduct an immediate safety review of all stretches of NH-66 where construction is in progress.

Air India Express told to refund special equipment fee

Holding mishandling by Air India Express crew of a special equipment booked by a customer as deficiency of service, a consumer court in Mangaluru has directed the airline to refund ₹2,000 that it had taken from the consumer as special equipment handling fee. It was told to pay a compensation of ₹20,000, and ₹5,000 towards litigation costs. The customer had found that his expensive equipment was placed on the baggage carousel along with other luggage. This was a contravention of the special equipment handling protocol for which he had paid a separate fee.

Naidu plays YSRCP for ‘false campaign’ against A.P. govt.

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Monday expressed confidence that the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) would better its 2024 performance even if the State went to polls immediately.

However, to sustain the performance, the coalition government should continue its good work while effectively countering the “malicious propaganda” unleashed by the YSR Congress Party (YSRCP), he added. Addressing the TDP’s Leadership Conclave at its central office near Mangalagiri, Mr. Naidu said the party would duly recog-



N. Chandrababu Naidu

nise leaders living up to expectations and asked the leaders and grassroots workers to have cordial relations with the alliance partners, the Jana Sena Party (JSP) and the BJP.

The YSRCP was running a false campaign and it should be exposed with concrete evidence, he said, citing the YSRCP’s claims on the Veligonda and the Polavaram projects as an

example. The YSRCP lacked the courage to confront the government on the floor of the Legislative Assembly. Instead, its leader Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy had been spreading all sorts of falsehoods through other forums, the Chief Minister said.

He suggested that the allegations being made by the YSRCP should be shown to be baseless through social media.

The purpose of forging the alliance with the JSP and the BJP was to save the State from a disaster caused by the YSRCP’s misrule, he said, and added that the government was working closely with the Centre and had fulfilled all the promises in spite of financial constraints.

Four-time Keralam MLA and cooperative activist passes away

The Hindu Bureau
PALAKKAD

Senior Congress leader and former MLA of Chittur, K. Achuthan, 76, died on Monday due to age-related ailments at a private hospital at Alathur here in Kerala.

Mr. Achuthan represented the Chittur constituency in the Assembly for four consecutive terms from 1996 to 2016, winning elections in 1996, 2001, 2006 and 2011. He also served as president of the Thathamangalam Service Cooperative Bank and chairman of the Chittur-Thathamangalam Municipality. A farmer and cooperative activist,



K. Achuthan

he had remained active in public life for several decades.

He is survived by his wife C.K. Sudha, son Suresh, who is the current MLA of Chittur, and daughter A. Sheeba, who is a lawyer. Leaders from different political and social circles condoled his death.

Central institute develops app to measure fish size hands-free

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute (CMFRI), headquartered in Kochi, Keralam, has claimed to have developed a smartphone application that can measure the length and width of fish without physically handling them.

Named MatsyaMetri, the application, which has been designed for fisheries scientists, researchers, and field survey teams, facilitates rapid and systematic collection of biological data to support fisheries assessment and management.

The application was developed by Eldho Vargh-



Representative photo.

ese, a senior scientist at the institute, according to a CMFRI release.

Grinson George, Director of the institute, said the application simplified biological data collection by automatically recording measurements and generating length-frequency datasets. The application allows multiple individuals

‘Lost in transition’: many former Mohalla Clinic staff await unpaid dues

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Since May 2025, the Delhi government has been setting up the Ayushman Arogya Mandirs (AAMs), which serve as primary healthcare centres, across the national capital. In phases, they replaced the Aam Aadmi Party government’s Mohalla Clinics, which are no longer operational. While many staff members were absorbed into AAMs, some say they have not received their final salaries and were told that the budget for the payments is “under consideration”.

There were 553 Mohalla Clinics. So far, the Delhi government has set up 415 AAMs and aims to establish 1,100 in all. The centres were envisaged to provide additional services such as maternal and child healthcare, routine immunisation, free screening for non-communicable diseases and nearly 80 types of free diagnostic tests.

However, some former Mohalla Clinic staff who were not absorbed into AAMs are still awaiting their dues. Dr. Amit Gupta, who worked at a clinic near Mandawali metro station, said he is owed ₹78,000. He said interviews for AAM posts were open to all staff and some were selected. He is currently practising at his own clinic.

In an e-mail to an east Delhi district Health official, Dr. Gupta wrote, “It is very unfortunate that our salaries for January and February are still pending.”

He received a response from an official on August 27, seen by *The Hindu*, stating that the file had been transferred to the respective cell and that “the approval of budget is under consideration”.

Another senior Delhi Health Department official said, “Many of them have been retained by AAMs and have received their salaries to date. If there has been any negligence, we will look into the matter.”

Pending dues

Mohalla Clinics employed four staff members each: a doctor, a pharmacist, a multi-task worker and a lab technician. AAMs have a similar staffing structure, though the number of personnel varies with the size of the centre.

A former multi-task worker at a Mohalla Clinic in the east district said, “I am trying to get a job in AAM but the vacancy has not opened yet. We have been told by supervisors that the funds have not been released for our last salaries. I have been without a job since March when the Mohalla Clinic shut.”

Another doctor said that besides salaries, which were linked to the number of patients seen, staff had not received other dues, including cleaning and costs incurred in transporting medicines, for the final month. “Authorities have said they are doubtful that it will come through but we are still waiting.”

Some staff have approached the Delhi High Court, which will hear them on September 8.



R. Sarath

Malayalam filmmaker Sarath is no more

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Filmmaker R. Sarath, known for his contemplative cinema that expressed environmental concerns, passed away at a hospital in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. He was 65.

Two years after India conducted nuclear tests at Pokhran, Sarath made *Sayahnam* (2000), his debut film that raised questions on the issue. It portrayed the story through the eyes of an ageing writer who is upset about the nuclear tests and his scientist son who celebrates the achievement. The film fetched him the Indira Gandhi Award for Best Debut Film of a Director, the National Film Award for Best Feature Film in Malayalam, and seven Kerala State Film Awards.

He followed it up with *Sthithi* (2003), a film that centres on the life of a couple employed in the government Secretariat, and *Seelabathi* (2005), a drama set in rural Keralam that revolves around the experiences of two young people who come from outside the village, which foregrounded how human greed destroyed nature.

He began his career as a journalist and later took to documentary filmmaking.

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HIMACHAL PRADESH INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT BOARD

(Government of Himachal Pradesh)

Pre-Proposal Conference(COE Wagnaghat)

The Government of Himachal Pradesh, through Himachal Pradesh Infrastructure Development Board (HPIDB), proposes to select/appoint an operator for the Upgradation, Operations, Maintenance and Management of the newly constructed Centre of Excellence, in Tourism and Hospitality Sector, at Wagnaghat, under Public-Private Partnership (PPP) mode. In this regard, the Government intends to hold a Pre-Proposal Conference with the prospective parties/bidders to obtain their feedback, suggestions and expectations prior to floating the tender/bid for the proposed project.

The Pre-Proposal Conference is scheduled to be held on **21-09-2026 at 11:00 AM.** at **HPTDC Hotel Meghdoot Wagnaghat on the Kalka-Shimla National Highway 5** at **Kiarighat, Kyari Bangla, Solan District, Himachal Pradesh, Pin code-173234.** It is advised that before attending the Pre-Proposal Conference, interested parties may visit the actual site of Centre of Excellence (Tourism and Hospitality Sector), at Wagnaghat, District Solan, HP, from 07th September 2026 to 19th September, 2026.

HPIDB looks forward to the active participation of all stakeholders/parties (Institutions in Hotel Industry, Hospitality Sector, Other related sector(s)) in shaping a transparent, sustainable and investor friendly PPP framework for the project.

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION, PLEASE CONTACT:

Chief General Manager Himachal Pradesh Infrastructure Development Board New Himra Building, Circular Road, Himnail Shimla-171001, Himachal Pradesh, India Phone No.: +91 177-2662696, 2627312. Email: hpdb-hp@nic.in; website: https://hpdb.hp.gov.in/	Managing Director, HPKVN, Directorate of Technical Education, Sundarnagar, Mandi-175018, Himachal Pradesh, India Phone No.: +91 1907-266120, 06230422191 Email: hpkvnshimla@gmail.com Website: https://hpkvn.in
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GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
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 BID NO. ETENDER/EE/PWSSD/ROPAR/40/2026/Date:03.09.2026

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2	Providing Sewerage System & all other works contingent thereto to at Sri Kiratpur Sahib Distt Ropar(Under SBM 2.0, Part 2)	As per DNIT

Closing date & Time → 21.09.2026 upto 3.00 PM.

Opening date & Time → 22.09.2026 upto 01.00 PM.

Prebid Meeting Date → 09.09.2026 at 09.00 A.M.

For detailed log onto <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>.

Note: Any Corrigendum (s), to the Tender/ RFP Notice shall be published on the above website only.

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CORRIGENDUM FOR DATE EXTENSION

The e-tender id no. 2026_PCKL_864827_1 for EOI for starting a suitable commercial project on B.O.T basis in Calicut city is hereby extended to **15.09.2026.**
(Sd/-) Managing Director

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Tender No.785 Date : 07.09.2026

Date Extension Notice-3

Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates in respect of online Bid Identification No.T-01/EE(Solar)/2026-27 are revised as follows:
 Last Date /Time of Receipt of :15-09-2026upto 16:00 Hrs.
 bid on the portal
 Last Date /Time of submission of :18-09-2026 upto 12:00 Hrs.
 bid in Office
 Date of opening of the bid on website :18-09-2026 from 13:00 Hrs.
 All other details and terms & conditions shall remain same. Detail of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc. may be obtained from the website.
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Natural partners

India and Belgium are building ties across sectors despite differences

In terms of size and engagement, Belgium is not one of India's most important partners. However, the visit of the Belgian Prime Minister to Delhi is part of a larger puzzle of India's ties with European countries. These have now gained salience with focus areas for India: in economic relations, defence relations and strategic ties. At the top of the agenda in talks between Prime Ministers Bart De Wever and Narendra Modi was bilateral trade opportunities once the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is signed – which is expected in December. India-Belgium trade is about \$13 billion, a third of which is from over a century of collaboration in the diamond industry. Antwerp is a global hub for diamond trading, while Mumbai and Surat provide the biggest cutting and polishing services. However, once the EU FTA is signed, they hope to benefit from collaboration in other areas including renewable energy and food processing; the Prime Ministers agreed to set a target of doubling bilateral trade in the next five years. Despite being surrounded by friendly European allies, Belgium has a robust high-tech defence industry – small arms, drone and counter-drone technology, ammunition and naval defence – and is keen to make inroads in the Indian market, with India seeking to diversify its procurement beyond global powers. The two sides agreed on an MoU for co-development of military hardware, and signed a letter of intent on defence cooperation. India will appoint a resident defence attaché to Brussels, complementing Belgium's move.

Statements by the two leaders, however, indicated that the visit went beyond the bilateral to a more geopolitical framing of strategic ties, both bilateral as well as between India and Europe. At a business event, Mr. De Wever said that Europe is now realising the truth of India's "warnings" on strategic autonomy from global powers and over dependence in trade and industrial production, in particular referring to China. After the talks, Mr. Modi said that democratic values, a market economy, and people-to-people ties make India and Belgium "natural partners", a theme he has promoted this past year, as he has stepped up visits to Europe and received a number of European leaders in Delhi, in the run-up to his Brussels visit later this year for the FTA. It is also significant that Mr. De Wever's visit comes in the same week that New Delhi is preparing to welcome Russian President Vladimir Putin for the BRICS summit in Delhi. The engagement with Belgium demonstrates a new maturity for both European countries and India. This shows sensitivity to their respective positions on the Russia-Ukraine conflict, indicating that ties outweigh Europe's enmity and India's deep friendship with Moscow.

Ground control

ISRO must focus on space technology as a tool for development

The irony was evident: on the day the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) had its greatest success of the year – the launch of its first geosynchronous imaging satellite (EOS-05) on a temperamental GSLV – its employee organisations demanded clarity on its long-term plans. But this grievance was long in the making. Since the Indian Space Policy of April 2023, the message has been clear that ISRO would, one day in the unspecified future, stop making commercial satellites and launch rockets. Clearly inspired by NASA, it expects to focus on ambitious exploratory missions and, literally, moonshots. Why would a space agency ramping up space missions upset a section of employees? This is not the paradox it presents. The letter, co-signed by nine employee associations, and addressed to the chairman, seeks clarity on staff-strength, recruitment and the outsourcing of core functions. ISRO says that it will "not be privatised or reduced"; IN-SPaCE, set up to facilitate private participation, says the agency will "not be diminished", only that the industry's role must grow. Both are silent on the core concern – potential job losses. This brings up an underlying tension that ISRO must deal with: does its vision of India's space sector align with its founding principles, of not being enamoured of space races and being laser-focused on space technology as a tool for social development? Or is the image of power, where India is one of a handful of space-faring countries with a mushrooming of 'space startups', now the bedrock of that vision?

With a budget 16 times the Department of Space's – \$24.4 billion against ₹13,705 crore – NASA too has scaled back since the 1960s: from 0.7% of American GDP in 1966 to 0.1% now, and from 36,000 civil servants at Apollo's peak to about 14,000 today. Unlike NASA, which in its early years designed and made every nut and bolt, ISRO has always had a manufacturing relationship with the private sector (Walchandnagar, L&T). What is different is that the buzz is not about established companies building on experience but new entrants with fleeting foreign capital, most interested in satellite data as a service. No sector can hope to be static; survival can mean significant changes to how it operates. There is yet no serious reckoning with the might of China's space programme. If India's space sector in 2035 is to be known as a source of export earnings, a nucleus of value-added services that brings in jobs and absorbs skilled labour, then hard choices taken today may be worth it. But jumping onto a bandwagon of space – as fuel for the science fiction fantasy of billionaires and colonial notions of conquest, to align with some misplaced notion of an 'exclusive' club – is foolhardy. ISRO must have a transparent policy that spells this out.

BRICS has strayed quite far from where it started. To be held this weekend (September 12-13, 2026) the 18th BRICS Summit, in New Delhi, gives India a huge opportunity to bring coherence back to the expanded group and give it direction if it is to be an effective body in shaping global events.

BRICS was formed to give a greater voice to Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, the emerging economies, in global governance and institutions, particularly financial and economic institutions, and to aim for a more equitable multilateral order. India was initially an enthusiastic participant, seeing the group as a vehicle for genuine reform of multilateral institutions. The first summit hosted by India (the fourth BRICS summit), in 2012, focused on the theme "Global Stability, Security and Prosperity," tacitly reflecting a much broader geopolitical canvas. The Indian presidency helped lead the establishment of the BRICS Bank, the New Development Bank. Other Indian initiatives followed, including the integration of a counter-terrorism architecture into BRICS' work.

The emergence of the China challenge

However, China had other plans. At the time, even if it was not anti-West, China saw BRICS as a counterpoise to western domination – a view that India also initially shared in the context of reform. More importantly, China needed a group such as BRICS, consisting of emerging economies, to amplify its global ambitions, given that BRICS countries accounted for nearly 20% of world GDP in 2010. Further, China wanted to use BRICS mechanisms such as BRICS-Plus and BRICS Outreach to reach out to the Global South and consolidate their profile as a second pole in a future bipolar world.

Suddenly, India not only had a reform agenda on its hands but also had to act as a counterweight to China's larger designs on BRICS. India, Brazil and South Africa soon realised that Chinese support for the reform of multilateral institutions was selective. For example, China resisted supporting the three countries' bid for permanent seats on the United Nations Security Council. Consequently, India started focusing more on BRICS consolidation and intra-BRICS matters to resist Chinese grandstanding. In fact, this year's theme for India's chairship has four pillars – Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability – and draws on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Humanity First" and a "people-centric" approach to BRICS cooperation.

In addition, there was a real danger that the principle of consensus, which had kept BRICS a cohesive group, would be bypassed and that BRICS would go the way of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), where the majority can bulldoze their views through. India and Brazil resisted these efforts. The 2019 BRICS Summit in Brasilia was held without any other invited guest countries – just the five original members. But in 2020, under the Russian presidency, probably the first non-consensus chair's statement on COVID-19 was issued,



T.S. Tirumurti

Chair, Steering Committee, Deccan Centre for International Relations, former Permanent Representative of India to the United Nations, New York, and former Sherpa of BRICS

The Delhi summit offers India an opportunity to restore BRICS's original purpose

bypassing the sacred principle of consensus. If non-consensus documents are increasingly resorted to, as we saw at the BRICS Foreign Ministers' meeting in May 2026 in New Delhi due to the inability of the new members to agree, then BRICS will cease to be effective.

Membership expansion tests BRICS cohesion

But then, it was difficult to resist the Chinese juggernaut. China pushed for the expansion of the New Development Bank and then for the expansion of BRICS itself. India resisted, as did Brazil. But that was not to be, and BRICS now has 11 members, following the addition of Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Indonesia, as well as 10 partner countries.

India's sagacity has now been vindicated, as the new members of BRICS have started fighting among themselves. While the original five have their differences, some of them serious, they know how to address them with maturity for the greater good of the group. The new members do not have any such compunctions and are subverting BRICS through their bilateral conflicts. BRICS should not go the way of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), with bilateral disputes paralysing the group.

In addition, the tussle over the direction BRICS should take has begun. India has tried to keep BRICS as a "non-West" group, as opposed to the increasing pressure from some members to turn BRICS into an anti-West group. An anti-West slant is becoming increasingly difficult to avoid, with China competing with the United States for global leadership, Russia at war with Ukraine with the full backing of Europe, and Iran being bombarded by the U.S. and Israel. It becomes even harder to maintain the "non-West" line when Brazil and India have been subjected to punitive tariffs by U.S. President Donald Trump, and the U.S. Congress is considering legislation that would give the President the power to levy punitive tariffs on countries importing Russian oil. The question being asked is: how can India stop BRICS from becoming anti-West at a time when the Quad (Australia, India, Japan, the U.S.) is being emasculated by the U.S., India-U.S. relations are under great pressure, Pakistan is being courted by the U.S. at India's expense, and global institutions are being made dysfunctional by the West? The more erratic the U.S. is *vis-à-vis* BRICS, the greater the chances of BRICS going in the wrong direction. Fortunately, India's effort to prevent an anti-western drift is shared by many other BRICS members, since they too have much to gain by engaging with multiple actors from different camps in their national interest. They want change, but not geopolitical realignment with China and Russia. This is the direction of BRICS's future.

But there is a much larger question. Both the U.S. and China are enunciating parallel visions of the world and playing by their own rules, rather than internationally negotiated ones. Both are, in effect, challenging existing international norms and global institutions and setting up parallel

structures and standards in emerging areas such as Artificial Intelligence, digital and Internet governance, data ownership, state control, 5G/6G and telecom, satellite navigation, and electric vehicles. Neither is looking for reform of existing institutions. China has just set up a new World AI Cooperation Organisation in Shanghai, in addition to other parallel initiatives such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, the Belt and Road Initiative and the Digital Silk Road, which challenge the Bretton Woods institutions and their governance and financing models. They see BRICS as one of the vehicles through which to pursue their broader goals. For example, the push for de-dollarisation through the establishment of a parallel BRICS currency is receiving a lukewarm response, since many members are uncomfortable with a renminbi-dominated currency and would prefer merely interlinking payment systems, central bank digital currencies and national-currency transactions. Nevertheless, after the success of its pilot project, China is formally launching its ambitious mBridge, an alternative financial payment system. The last thing India wants is an alternative Bretton Woods system dominated by China.s

India can course correct BRICS

The 2026 Summit in Delhi provides an opportunity for course correction, and India has worked hard to persuade the new members to overcome their political differences. In a world in flux, India has to revive the original *raison d'être* of BRICS and shape the expanded grouping into a vehicle for reform and stability, while stopping others from hijacking it.

At the 2018 BRICS Summit in South Africa, Mr. Modi first articulated his vision of "reformed multilateralism" at the leaders' retreat. By 2019, this vision had found its way into the BRICS Summit document in Brasilia, with India, Brazil and South Africa pushing for it. The time has come to revive this agenda and make BRICS a strong voice for the "non-West" middle powers – and, by extension, for the Global South.

In Davos, the Canadian Prime Minister spoke about broadly West-centric middle powers coming together. A Global South middle power is very different. And if there is a credible organisation of Global South middle powers, it is BRICS. It has its problems. To begin with, China is hardly a middle power and has disproportionate influence within BRICS. India and China need to find greater synergy on emerging global issues, even as their bilateral differences are being contained. Further, some middle powers that ought to be there are not represented in BRICS. However imperfect its composition may be, it is clear that BRICS has great geopolitical and geo-economic potential.

At a time when the profile of BRICS is only increasing, with many countries wanting to join it, India should proactively embrace the BRICS reform agenda to serve its larger interest of multi-alignment. If India does not, others will take BRICS in a different direction.

U.S. tariffs are not what is holding back Indian research

Tariff wars with the United States have ebbed and flowed for years. After months of escalation, Washington and New Delhi stepped back a few months ago. The penalty tied to India's purchases of Russian oil went, the reciprocal tariff was cut, and medicines and most electronics stayed exempt. Exporters treated it as relief. But an old worry in policy circles is worth testing: that high American tariffs will choke research in the industries that they touch, and set back India's move into higher-value production.

The reality

That worry rests on a mistaken assumption that the sectors exposed to American tariffs are the sectors where India does its research.

Consider the impact of the 2019 loss of duty-free access and the 2025 tariff hit on sectors such as organic chemicals, plastics, base metals, machinery, auto components, and leather. Now consider how much these industries do in research. Indian metals firms spend about 0.4% of sales on R&D, compared with a global average of nearly 1.6%. Auto and parts makers spend a little over 2%, versus a global average of 5%, while electrical equipment firms spend less than 2%, against the same 5% global benchmark. These industries were research-thin long before any tariff arrived. The sectors most exposed to trade shocks and the sectors that invest in research barely overlap. India's research effort is concentrated in pharmaceuticals and automobiles, and almost everything else does little. A tariff on chemicals or steel cannot cut research spending that was never there.

This also takes the air out of the claim that tariffs are holding back Indian innovation. Patenting and research spending in the exposed sectors show no clear break during the tariff years that can be attributed to the duties. These sectors had been on a low-research path well



Arindam Goswami

Research Analyst at the Takshashila Institution, Bengaluru

The sectors most exposed to trade shocks barely overlap with those that invest in research

before 2018 and stayed on it. The tariffs are a symptom of a trading relationship under strain.

Research is a fixed and risky investment that pays off only when a product sells at scale. A firm facing a smaller export market can retreat to cheaper, undifferentiated goods, or invest in products that a tariff cannot easily replace. Indian industry has chosen the first path for decades, and a tariff does not change that habit.

Where tariffs do matter is narrow. Of the two sectors that account for most of India's research, pharmaceuticals secured an exemption in the February deal, while automobiles did not. The 25% U.S. duty on auto parts remains, and metal tariffs raise input costs for downstream engineering and component firms. So, the live risk to India's research base runs through autos – not the broad manufacturing economy that fills the headlines.

The real problem

The problem to worry about predates this trade fight and will outlast it. India spends a very small percentage of its output on research, a figure that remains well below that of the countries it wants to compete with. The private industry share is also well below the global leaders. What industry does spend tends to go toward routine development and testing rather than research that creates new products. By one comparison, Nvidia alone spends nearly as much on research as all of Indian industry combined.

This is the backdrop for the government's ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation scheme, launched late last year. It offers long-tenure, low-cost capital to firms in sunrise and strategic areas such as artificial intelligence, semiconductors, quantum technology and biotechnology. The ambition is overdue. But the money is pointed at the frontier, while the industries most exposed to trade shocks

and most in need of moving up the value chain are older sectors that the scheme is not designed for. A chemicals or auto-parts maker that has never run a research programme will not start now because of a loan aimed at deep tech.

That is the opportunity the tariff episode offers. A trade shock tells an exposed industry that its products are vulnerable. The useful response is to move those firms into differentiated products that a tariff cannot easily undercut, which means investing in research. Incentives can be weighted towards core research rather than routine testing and aimed at exposed sectors instead of being spread thin. The higher costs that metal tariffs cause on downstream engineering firms can be offset for those that keep up research spending. Pharmaceuticals and autos also deserve protection in any further negotiations, because tariffs in these sectors can affect innovation. Sheltering an exposed industry without asking anything in return preserves low-value production. Support should be tied to research effort, so that relief rebuilds capability rather than freezing the status quo.

Time to measure research better

None of this works without better measurement. India's official research figures arrive years late and undercount private spending. A country that cannot see where its research is going cannot steer it. A faster, firm-level record linking research spending to exports would let policymakers act before the damage shows.

The tariff truce gives India time. The tariffs were never the main thing holding back Indian research. The task is to fix what is: an economy whose exposed industries do too little research, while its research strength is in a few sectors that could be vulnerable to the next trade shock.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A dam, the concerns

China's proposed colossal dam on the Yarlung Tsangpo has precipitated profound geopolitical and ecological apprehensions. The region's pronounced seismicity renders such an enormous hydraulic structure particularly

disquieting. The absence of an enforceable transboundary water-sharing mechanism further exacerbates India's predicament. China must institutionalise hydrological transparency. **Nagarajamani M.V.,** Hyderabad

Assembly proceedings

Of late, the Tamil Nadu Assembly appears to have become more of a shooting spot than a place for serious debate. Members shout at the top of their voices, while 'cheerleaders' from the respective political parties

enthusiastically thump the tables — often without even understanding what is actually being discussed. There was much hype surrounding the Chief Minister's response to the points raised by the Leader of the Opposition. But in the end, it turned out to be

nothing more than a damp squib. Allegations were made without producing evidence, while the much-talked-about 'files' are still waiting to be opened. Only a handful of members appear to be focusing on people's welfare and the real issues affecting

them. Meanwhile, the larger concern remains the deterioration of law and order in Tamil Nadu.

R. Shankar, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Teen agency beyond Meta’s reckoning

Meryl is 13. She describes YouTube Shorts as “so addicting”; holding her attention “just long enough” that she loses track of everything else. She is one of dozens of teens who have participated in the research at the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab at Rutgers University. While the 13-year-old’s language is not unusual, teen voices are still largely missing from broader debates about social media use.

Meta’s \$17.1 billion settlement with U.S. States is making headlines as a reckoning over addictive platform design. However, not much has been said about how teen agency emerges in a media environment built to predict the most tempting feed. Debates about youth and technology have historically focused on media effects: either what teens do with media, or what media does to teens. Nearly 100 years ago, the Payne Fund Studies marked the first systematic exploration of this dynamic, examining the impact of movies on children. With every new wave of technology, the storyline persists. Youth audiences are typically spoken for – cast as passive, trapped or targeted by new tech.

This framing misses the point. It ignores how the experience of adolescence itself shapes media use, and why certain types of media design captivate teens. Teens’ media use resonates with a powerful framework from developmental psychology: a race car that can go very fast, but whose brakes are still being built. That speed creates both opportunities and risks. Teens are primed to learn



Nikhila Natarajan

Co-founder of the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab at Rutgers University

more rapidly than at any other stage of development. Yet that power makes teens more vulnerable to negative stimuli. This heightened sensitivity exists alongside a crucial asymmetry: their ability to plan and prioritise (what to do first, what next) develops gradually, even as teens exhibit heightened sensitivity to “rewards” (easily persuaded by things that are pleasing). In today’s media, these rewards arrive via personalised recommendations. When short-form video loops shrink the gap between media experiences to 15 or 30 seconds, the onus of decision-making becomes the young person’s problem at a time when the braking system is still getting built.

Whistleblowers, Silicon Valley defectors, and documentaries such as *The Social Dilemma* have laid bare how platform design choices erode human agency. What remains absent from public commentary is what teens’ vocabularies reveal about their developmental needs. Across the 13-to-16 age group, teens say that short-form videos are shrinking their attention spans. But their reflections point to a persistent entry point: boredom.

Boredom, peer dynamics
Boredom is a developmental driver. As adolescents shift their orientation toward peers and crave greater independence, they continue to live under adult restrictions. They then open an app seeking a quick distraction, only to find themselves stuck for hours on platforms such as YouTube Shorts or TikTok.

Peer dynamics drive how teens move across different apps, with platform design acting as an amplifier. On platforms such as Instagram and Snapchat, where popularity is quantified

through public likes and follower counts, every interaction gets a scoreboard. For an adolescent hyper-sensitive to social inclusion and exclusion, this design is incredibly stressful. Early evidence from Australia’s social media ban bears this out. Two systematic surveys by Bursztyan and colleagues found that Australian teens report needing roughly 70% of their peers to quit social media before they’re willing to quit themselves.

Research at the Teens, Family, and Technology Lab shows that adolescents navigate an average of 7 to 12 different platforms daily. Instagram and Facebook exist within a competitive teen media inventory alongside Snapchat, YouTube, Pinterest, Discord, Spotify, and more. Here, teens’ recalibration of media practices, and parents’ concerns for their children’s wellbeing act as powerful competitive forces.

While Meta and other platforms chase topline revenues, some teens are crafting micro-frictions to push back. Pinterest is a big hit with girls who want to escape performative sociality; music streaming competes with short-form video apps; and some teens are deleting apps intermittently. These are behavioural signatures of adolescent metacognition – literally, thinking about thinking. Yet AI-fuelled media design continues to operate at the limits of adolescent development, exacerbating tensions between the intentional and accidental. Understanding the contradictions of adolescent development invites us to reconsider teen media use in a new light – as a striving for agency.

The incongruity of caste and science

All humans must be treated equally. That is a moral and constitutional position. It is not a scientific position because science does not carry moral or constitutional authority.

The normative system laid out in the ‘Manusmriti’ expresses the ‘principle’ that the birth of a person says something essential about who that person is supposed to be, with persons born into specific social categories to be assigned a place in the division of labour and a set of permitted relationships and social rights. Modern constitutional thinking is radically different. Per the Magna Carta, the English Bill of Rights and the constitutional democracies of today, individuals possess rights that depend on more than their place in a social hierarchy. After all, the fundamental rights of the Indian Constitution are attached to persons and citizens, not to inherited social functions.

Yet a poster that turned up at IIT-Mandi on September 4 said the role of “Brahmanas” is to “spread god’s message”, that of “kshatriyas” to “protect society and spirituality”, of “vaishyas” to “drive economy, support others”, and of “shudras” to “serve higher classes”.

Science, which underlies the technologies the IITs are primarily concerned with, offers another conception paralleling the constitutional view, rooted in a different kind of authority.

The authority of science
While some defenders of the caste system have claimed that it is based on inherited biological differences, the system is really the cause of the differences, rather than their inheritor. The human



Vasudevan Mukunth

organism develops as its genes interact with its environment, and caste-based discrimination affects these environments. Studies on the social determinants of health have revealed caste-related inequities in healthcare and access to healthcare while social epigenetics has found that social circumstances can induce biological changes via mechanisms that affect the way genes are regulated.

People of Black African heritage and Indigenous peoples in Asia, say, have non-identical genomes for this reason. By applying science’s methods, we know the differences between these peoples do not excuse a caste-like system. Instead, the differences in these people’s social circumstances through history – including societies of which they were part practising a hereditary, hierarchical system at any point – affected the way they developed.

In a landmark 2009 study, geneticists reported that most present-day Indians descended from two differentiated ancient populations, which mixed extensively before endogamy took root, and present Indian groups contain mixes of these ancestries. The team also said there are substantial genetic differences between various communities today thanks to a long history of endogamy. Other studies of Indian populations have also reported strong founder effects (when a new population emerges from a small group of individuals and inherits the lack of genetic diversity) due to endogamy. The genome does not announce that these people were ordained

to marry one another but records the fact that they elected to do so for reasons beyond scientific wisdom.

The human nervous system is also very plastic: it constantly rewires itself in response to every experience in a life-long process. Not everyone is good at everything, but plasticity means the neurological system develops together with each human’s environment, interests, temperament, and individual choice, giving rise to a variety of abilities among people.

No matter how well-equipped, the practice of science could never say whether all humans are equal. That is a political and ethical proposition it cannot test or prove. However, it does say that all humans are members of one species, that their development is shaped by their experiences, and that social environments can become embodied.

Just as caste constrains the plasticity of the human brain, it also constrains the human capacity for culture. *Homo sapiens* can accumulate knowledge and pass it on so that other *H. sapiens* do not have to learn from scratch. Caste-based discrimination, however, restricts the spread of knowledge and narrows the social range over which one of the defining capacities of our species can operate – as if a student’s ability to solve a differential equation has anything to do with the status of their ancestors.

This clash of possibilities is what makes the appearance of a message reinforcing the caste system at a centre of scientific learning particularly tragic.

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Nearly 8,000 people died due to collapse of structures in 5 years

While the incident in Satya Niketan in Delhi has sparked outrage, hundreds of people have been dying due to laxities in enforcing building safety norms.

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A

The collapse of a five-storey building in Satya Niketan in Delhi on September 6, in which six people have been confirmed dead as of Monday morning, has turned out to be yet another grim reminder of the laxity in cracking down on buildings violating safety norms.

While collapses like the one in Satya Niketan have caught the public’s attention, because of the high death toll and the fact that it was a PG for students, many such isolated incidents which happen across the country go largely unnoticed.

An analysis of the annual Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) reports showed that a total of 7,874 people were killed in building collapses across the country between 2020 and 2024. Delhi recorded 169 deaths in the same period.

The ADSI 2024 report – the latest available from the National Crime Records Bureau – stated that while such deaths showed a marginal decline in the country in 2024, the deaths in the National Capital Territory (NCT) have increased since 2020 (**Chart 1**).

The ADSI includes five sub-categories under deaths due to collapse of structures – Collapse of Dwelling House/Residential Building, Collapse of Official/Commercial Building, Collapse of Dam, Collapse of Bridge, and Others. The data discussed in this article excludes the numbers reported under the categories of ‘Collapse of Dam’ and ‘Collapse of Bridge’.

Uttar Pradesh, the most populous State in the country, recorded 223 deaths due to building collapses in 2024, the highest in the country. It was followed by the second most populous State, Maharashtra (as per Census 2011) with 220 deaths. **Chart 2** shows the 15 States and UTs that reported the

highest number of deaths due to building collapses.

Delhi reported the 12th highest number of deaths (42) in the country in 2024. Despite being geographically smaller, the densely-populated NCT has been among the top 15 States every year since 2020. Moreover, the deaths recurring every year in the capital are more worrying when seen in relation to its population. Deaths from building collapses per million population, calculated using mid-year population estimates from the ADSI reports every year, show that Delhi recorded the second- or third-highest deaths per million population in 2022, 2023, and 2024 (**Chart 3**).

Recent numbers

While the ADSI report for 2025 is yet to be released, a compilation of incidents reported in the media showed that at least 70 people have died in 20 incidents since January 2025, which means that at least three people have died every month in such incidents.

Map 1 shows the incidents reported in the media since 2024, including the one in Satya Niketan on Sunday. There have been at least 34 incidents, killing more than 90 people since 2024.

Acting in predictable haste, as most government agencies do after such incidents, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, has said that it will seal all illegal five-storey and taller buildings “immediately”.

However, data discussed in this article indicates that the underlying systemic problem demands well-thought-out long-term strategies that keep in mind the growing need for affordable housing to end such avoidable deaths.

Note on map: The incidents and death toll were compiled from news reports. Though each incident has been verified from at least three news reports, there may be some inaccuracies in the numbers. Incident locations are geocoded to locality level, and not the precise spot of the incident.

Accountability collapse

The data for the charts were sourced from annual Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India reports. DataMeet’s Delhi municipal spatial data was used to plot the map. Incidents plotted in the map were sourced from media reports. With inputs from Gauri Singavarapu and Gandla Sneha, who are interning with The Hindu’s Data team



CHART 1: Deaths due to building collapses have increased in Delhi. Y-axis scales are different for All India and Delhi

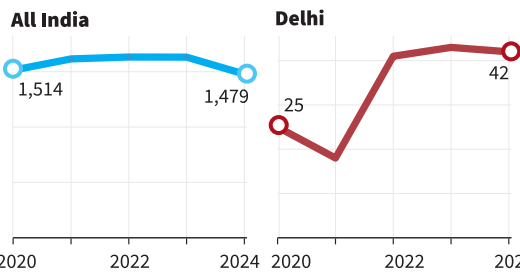
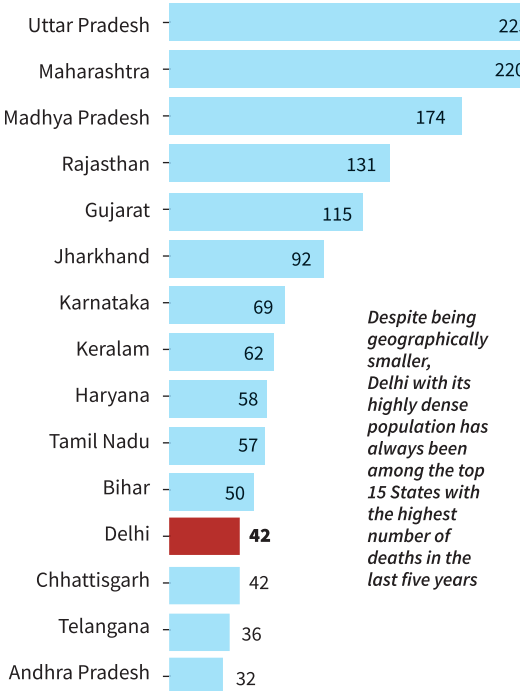
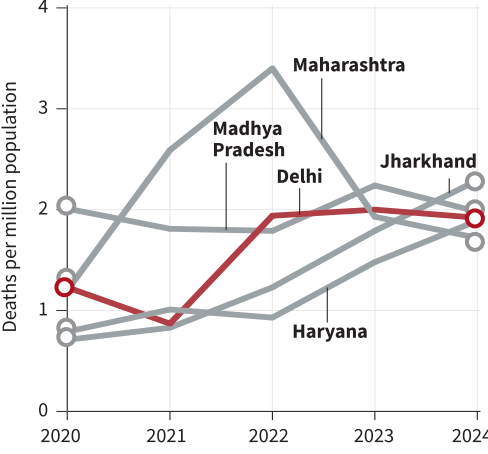


CHART 2: The 15 States (or UTs) with the highest number of deaths due to building collapses in 2024

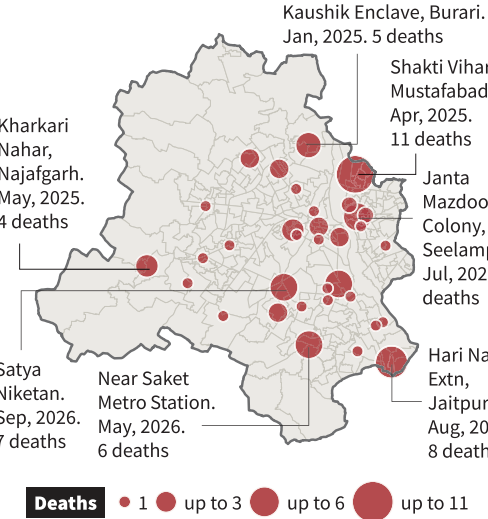


Despite being geographically smaller, Delhi with its highly dense population has always been among the top 15 States with the highest number of deaths in the last five years

CHART 3: Delhi recorded the second or third highest deaths per million due to building collapses since 2022



MAP 1: In at least 34 incidents of building collapses since 2024 in various parts of Delhi, over 90 people were killed



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 8, 1976

Bhutto lays claim to Kohinoor diamond

London, September 7: Pakistan has asked Britain to return the fabulous Kohinoor diamond which is the central stone in the Queen Consort’s crown and has been in British possession since 1849.

A Government spokesman said to-day the request was made in a personal letter to the Prime Minister, Mr. James Callaghan by the Pakistani Premier, Z. A. Bhutto. It was “being considered”.

The 100 carat gem now stored in the Tower of London is acknowledged as the finest diamond in the world and became part of the crown jewels of Queen Victoria after the British annexed Punjab. The 1,000-year-old diamond was last worn by the Queen Mother at the Coronation of King George VI in 1937.

A spokesman for Queen Elizabeth to-day would not comment on the monarch’s authority to accede to President Bhutto’s request.

The palace spokesman said Prime Minister Callaghan was likely to discuss the request with the Queen.

Informed sources said the Pakistani Premier wrote in his letter that the return of the stone would be a demonstration of the spirit that moved Britain to shed its imperial emburances.

The request for the coveted Kohinoor – ‘Mountain of Light’ – might become another chapter in the turbulent history of the stone.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 8, 1926

South Africa’s status

Capetown, September 7: General Hertzog’s speech at a meeting in the City Hall on the eve of his departure to attend the Imperial Conference dealing with the Flag Bill has foreshadowed a compromise and he declared that if the Committee on the flag should recommend the inclusion of a crown in it he was confident that the Government would approve it.

Gen. Hertzog denied that he intended at the conference to demand a written constitution and said he intended to urge that steps should be taken so that South Africa’s national status which was equal to that of Britain and other dominions be entitled to an international recognition and should be so published and declared to the world.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount unveiled by EU chief for Greenland package

232 in \$ million. European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen unveiled on Monday a 200-million-euro (\$232 million) investment package for Greenland, as the EU seeks to boost its relations with the island. “Greenland can count on the EU,” she said. AP

Teachers who launched a sit-in over recruitment

1,000 Over 1,000 teachers who lost their jobs following court rulings launched a sit-in outside the West Bengal Education Department headquarters, ‘Bikash Bhavan’, on Monday, demanding that the State government expedite their recruitment. PTI

Number of names deleted from Mizoram electoral rolls after SIR

78,442 Mizoram’s electoral rolls underwent a significant change during the SIR exercise, with 78,442 names deleted and 39,243 new electors added, taking the state’s final voter count to 8.35 lakh, a senior official said on Monday. PTI

Decline in road accidents in U.P. under ZFD scheme

6.97 in per cent. Uttar Pradesh recorded a 6.97% decline in road accidents, an 8.03% fall in fatalities, and a 6.11% reduction in injuries at locations covered under the Zero Fatality District scheme between January and August this year, police said on Monday. PTI

Persons booked for drunk driving in Keralam

2,799 The police in Keralam registered cases against 2,799 people for allegedly driving under the influence of alcohol during a week-long special drive across the State, a police spokesman said on Monday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Are nicotine pouches beyond the law?

Does COTPA cover nicotine pouches? Why are they not covered by the law banning vapes? Could nicotine pouches be treated as food under Indian law? Can they be legally imported into India? Can nicotine pouches be sold at duty-free shops?

EXPLAINER

Murali Neelakantan

The story so far:

A new study led by the ICMR-National Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research has found that nicotine pouches are reaching Indian cities through online platforms, hookah shops and gig delivery services. The study comes after a warning from the World Health Organization in May 2026 about the dangers these products pose. Yet it is far from settled which Indian law, if any, governs them.

What are nicotine pouches?

A nicotine pouch is a small, tobacco-free, tea-bag-like sack containing nicotine, flavourings and plant-based fibres. Users place the pouch between the lip and gum for up to an hour, allowing nicotine to be absorbed directly into the bloodstream without smoke, vapour or spitting.

Does COTPA cover nicotine pouches?

The Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act, 2003 (COTPA) governs the marketing, advertising and sale of cigarettes and other tobacco products. But its definition of tobacco products does not extend to all products containing nicotine. Had the legislature intended to cover every extract of the tobacco plant, it could have said so. Restrictions on the freedom of trade and commerce must be strictly construed and since nicotine pouches are not among the products listed in the Cigarettes Act, they fall outside it.

Are they regulated by the Drugs Act?

Nicotine is not listed as a drug in any schedule of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940. Nicotine patches and gums have, however, been approved as drugs by the Drug Controller General of India for therapeutic use in treating nicotine addiction. Schedule K under the Drugs and Cosmetics Rules, 1945 lists gums and lozenges and exempts them from licensing and prescription requirements if they contain less than 2 mg of nicotine. If nicotine were not considered a drug



GETTY IMAGES

at all, there would be no reason to exempt certain nicotine products in Schedule K. The very fact that only some nicotine products are exempted suggests that all others are meant to be regulated by the Drugs Act.

Against this, pouches are arguably unlike patches and gums. They make no therapeutic claim and do not purport to treat addiction; they are a substitute for cigarettes. On this reading, they do not qualify as drugs under the Drugs Act.

Why are they not covered by the law banning vapes?

The import and sale of vapes is banned by the Prohibition of Electronic Cigarettes Act, 2019 (“PECA”). If vapes were drugs, no separate legislation would have been needed: the government could have regulated them, or refused licences, under the Drugs Act. The enactment of PECA therefore suggests that the Drugs Act did not give it adequate power to ban them. Nicotine pouches are different from vapes: they contain no electronic device and produce neither smoke nor vapour. They are consequently not covered by PECA.

Could pouches be treated as food?

The Prevention of Food Adulteration Act and the Food Safety and Standards Act define food broadly: any processed, partially processed or unprocessed substance intended for human consumption. Court rulings on supari and chewing tobacco establish that the

definition has a very wide amplitude, encompassing items that are chewed rather than swallowed. It is arguable, then, that nicotine pouches could fall within the broad definition of food.

Can pouches be imported into India?

Import restrictions flow from two statutes: the Foreign Trade (Development and Regulation) Act, 1992 and the Customs Act, 1962. The Foreign Trade Act empowers the Central government to prohibit, restrict or regulate imports; the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) administers this and publishes the ITC-HS classification listing which goods are free, restricted or banned. Section 11 of the Customs Act allows the government to prohibit goods wholly or partly by notification, on grounds that include the protection of human, animal or plant life.

After the World Customs Organization updated the Harmonized System, a sub-category was introduced for oral nicotine products that do not involve combustion: 2404 91 30 covers tobacco-free single-use pouches of the Zyn or Lyft type, and 2404 91 90 covers other oral nicotine products not meant for therapeutic uses. These replaced a residual category for other manufactured tobacco substitutes; the codes for medicaments apply only where a product is strictly a cessation aid. Under the DGFT schedule and the rules of the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs, goods under 2404 91 30 are “restricted”.

Unlike “free” items, they cannot be cleared merely on payment of duty, and unlike “prohibited” e-cigarettes, they are not banned outright – but they require a specific licence or permission. In deciding, the DGFT cross-references the health and other ministries.

What about duty-free shops?

Nicotine pouches are currently available at a few duty-free stores at Indian airports. Such stores are licensed under Section 58 of the Customs Act and cannot claim to be entirely outside Indian law.

It is sometimes said that a duty-free shop lies outside the territory of India, and that it is the passenger who imports the goods on crossing customs control. In *Flemingo Duty Free Shop Pvt. Ltd. v. Shri Kaushik Bhattacharya* (2024), the Calcutta High Court held that a duty-free store did not “import” goods into India, being deemed to be located outside it for the purposes of the Customs Act, and that legal metrology labelling requirements therefore did not apply. This should not be read to mean no Indian law applies to duty-free shops. If no Indian law applied to stores, could they stock arms and ammunition? If a crime was committed in a duty free store, which court would have jurisdiction to try the case? Which police station would have jurisdiction to register a case? That would be just too absurd.

Cigarettes, alcohol, jewellery, watches, food and small electronic items are some of the goods permitted at duty-free shops. Nicotine pouches are not – unless one can argue they are food. Given their customs classification as restricted, it is unlikely that any import licence has been granted.

What is the legal position?

The legal position is intricate, but the remedy is not. A notification under the Customs Act and the Foreign Trade Act banning the import and sale of nicotine pouches on health grounds would take minutes to issue. If the government moves as slowly as it did with vapes, pouches will become fashionable, and demand will settle in. A ban notified after that point will only produce smuggling on the scale we now see with vapes and cause damage to health that will be hard to mitigate. (Murali Neelakantan is a lawyer)

THE GIST

▼ Nicotine pouches are not covered by COTPA or PECA, while their status under the Drugs Act is debatable. They could also arguably fall within the broad definition of food

▼ Tobacco-free, single-use nicotine pouches require a specific licence or permission under the DGFT’s ITC-HS classification; they are not prohibited outright like e-cigarettes

▼ The government can prohibit their import and sale on health grounds. Delaying action could lead to established demand and smuggling, as seen with vapes

What could have prompted the latest hike in LPG prices?

How are under-recoveries shaping LPG pricing, and what could be its wider impact?

Saptaparno Ghosh

The story so far:

After two successive months of decline in LPG prices, oil-marketing companies hiked prices of the commercial variant of the bottled hydrocarbon gas by approximately ₹10 per cylinder across the country on September 1. The 19-kg cylinder in Delhi now costs ₹2,747.5 per cylinder whilst the price of the 14.2-kg cylinder remains unchanged.

What is the latest price hike about?

Industry observers state the latest hike in the commercial segment primarily caters to offset the under-recoveries (that is, the losses OMCs incur because of the difference in prices at which they sell to consumers against the price they should receive for meeting the cost of

production and distribution) for the domestic segment.

The latest government data reported that India’s State-owned oil-marketing companies were incurring under-recoveries of ₹188 per domestic cylinder in early August, down from ₹500 per cylinder in July and more than ₹700 per cylinder in June. According to data, the packaged domestic segment accounted for 90.4% of all LPG consumption in the country during April and June this year. Further, about 10.6 crore Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala scheme beneficiaries – approximately 33% of the domestic segment – receive an additional subsidy of ₹300 per cylinder.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Prashant Vashisht, senior vice president and co-group head, corporate sector ratings, at ratings agency ICRA, said, “At present,

the under-recovery on domestic LPG cylinders is hovering at about ₹200 per cylinder. Thus, the latest hike potentially tries to somewhat compensate for that amount, although the proportionate sales of commercial LPG are much smaller [compared to the domestic variant]. I would not read much into it”.

What does the supply situation look like?

On the supply side, imports of petroleum, oil and lubricants (POL) products registered a decline of 45.1% between April and July this year, according to data from the government’s Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC). It attributed this to “reduction in imports of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), pet coke and fuel oil (FO) etc.”

However, essential to note that India’s oil-marketing companies ramped up their

daily production of bottled hydrocarbon gas from 34,000 metric tonnes to 55,000 metric tonnes to offset the impact of lower imports. Further, following an August 13 directive, India’s upstream companies, along with private and public oil-marketing companies have been set a daily production target of 63,810 metric tonnes.

Are we looking at a potential impact?

Speaking to *The Hindu* earlier, Manpreet Singh, treasurer at the National Restaurants Association of India, said the impact of the latest hike, standalone, would be “negligible” although it may prompt concerns about price increases in the future.

Although it is essential to note the impact from the industrial segment, which requires bottled hydrocarbon gas to run their furnaces, such as in the glass-making industry and elevated demand is expected to seep in because of the festive season. However, the segment too is increasingly transitioning to piped natural gas, seeking secure and consistent supplies. According to data from the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB), industrial sales of piped gas increased by 30% between April and June this year compared to the same period last year.

THE GIST

▼ Commercial LPG prices rose by about ₹10 per cylinder as OMCs seek to offset domestic LPG under-recoveries

▼ Lower imports are being offset by higher domestic production, while the impact on businesses is expected to be limited for now

CACHE

Can air-cooling handle the heat from a 1-GW data centre?

Air-cooling uses less water and is cheaper and well-established, but it cannot practically handle the heat load of a 1-GW data centre on its own; while liquid-cooling imposes higher costs upfront, air-cooling imposes a performance and efficiency tax

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

Following sustained local protests and pressure from civil society groups, Google has reportedly said its planned 1-GW data centre in Visakhapatnam district will use air-cooling technology to cool its servers. While air-cooling requires less water, it comes with its own trade-offs.

Why does a large data centre generate heat?

A large data centre will have several million processors, each with billions of transistors. Each transistor manipulates the electrical current flowing through it to perform operations on data. As it does, the resistance the transistor's material poses to the flow of current will release some heat, as will the charging and discharging of transistors. Across trillions of transistors, the amount of heat thus generated can be considerable.

A 1-GW data centre will in principle produce 1 GW of heat. The planned Google 'hyperscaler' near Visakhapatnam and the newly announced Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) 'HyperVault' will each be 1-GW facilities. How much of that power is for the data centre alone is unclear. Assuming it is 1 GW: each facility will effectively have to remove 1 GW of heat out of and into the environment. In the very first step, the heat from each chip is moved from the silicon die holding it to a designated heat sink, such as a cooling plate. But what happens from the heat sink depends on which cooling technology the facility uses.

How does a data centre move heat?

Since the heat comes from transistors, it helps to understand the architecture first. Billions of transistors make a processor. One or more processors make up a server. Multiple servers fill a rack. Multiple racks are combined into clusters. Multiple clusters make up one data centre.

There are several cooling options depending on economic feasibility, scale of operations, and local conditions.

In air-cooling, fans push cool air through or around the server racks, and the hot air at the end is collected and cooled. Some common configurations include computer-room ACs (CRACs), which use ACs with refrigerants; computer-room air-handlers (CRAHs), which use chilled water to cool the air; hot-aisle/cold-aisle containment, where hot and cool air are kept physically separate; and free-cooling, where heat from servers is simply expelled into naturally cooler outside air. A related version is the rear-door heat exchanger: air leaving the servers passes through a heat-exchanger attached to the back of each rack, where chilled water absorbs the heat, and the cooler air is reflowed to the servers.

Another popular option is direct liquid cooling, where a specific liquid is brought in contact with the components generating heat. In one version called cold-plate cooling, a metal plate embedded with channels to carry the liquid is placed directly against a processor. The liquid draws the heat via the plate and flows from there via tubes to a heat-exchanger, where it loses the heat, before returning. Liquid-cooling is usually more effective than air-cooling because water-based liquids typically have higher



Close encounters: An Amazon Web Services data centre adjacent to single-family homes in Stone Ridge, Virginia, U.S. AFP

heat capacity than air, for the same volume. The heat capacity of a substance is the amount of heat it has to be given to raise its temperature by, say, 1° C. So the higher its heat capacity, the more heat it can absorb before itself warming up.

That said, the server can still air-cool those components that do not merit liquid-cooling. Third is an option called immersion cooling, where the electronics themselves are immersed in a non-conductive liquid. In single-phase immersion, the liquid draws heat, which is pumped away through a heat-exchanger. In two-phase immersion, the liquid boils as it draws heat; the heat is drawn away, e.g., by a fan, and the vapour condenses back. The latter is useful because heat transfer is more efficient at higher temperatures.

Because the heat-sink of a liquid is in contact with the electronics, the heat is moved more efficiently, and so immersion cooling can handle very high power densities. However, it requires specialised hardware and maintaining the coolant through complex processes.

Fourth is evaporative cooling: the heat is removed from the servers, e.g., using air-cooling, then transferred to water, which is then allowed to evaporate in cooling towers or evaporative condensers. If the local air isn't very humid, evaporative cooling can be highly energy-efficient. However, it requires large quantities of water.

Another similar option is dry-cooling, where a heat-exchanger is simply exposed to the ambient air and fitted with large fins to encourage the heat to leave. While this avoids the water demand of evaporative cooling, it also incurs larger heat-exchange surfaces, especially in places with warm weather.

Then there are chilled-water systems that use a central chilled water plant; geothermal heat rejection, an experimental technology where the heat is pumped into heat-exchangers underground; natural water cooling, where a large, natural water body like a nearby lake is used as the heat sink; and

heat reuse, where the heat is moved to serve applications like industrial processes or desalination.

All of them come with trade-offs. E.g. the geothermal option is hard to scale up while reusing heat is hard without heat pumps because the heat usually needs to be at a higher temperature to be useful.

Is air-cooling good?

Generally, air-cooling imposes lower infrastructure costs up front than a liquid-cooling setup. Current construction benchmarks suggest liquid-cooled facilities will incur a 7-10% premium on the total project cost due to the demand for complex piping and leak detection systems and special coolant distribution units.

Air-cooling is also a proven technology by now and comes with a deep and mature pool of technicians and maintenance protocols. In fact, irrespective of the cooling technology used in a cluster's heat hotspots, engineers often prefer to air-cool racks producing 20 kW or less of heat. It is an added bonus if the ambient conditions are naturally cool or arid, in which case air-side economisers that pull in outside air for cooling purposes can reduce the energy diverted to mechanical cooling by 70%. But all this said, as of 2026, using air-cooling alone to cool a 1-GW data centre is considered impractical, both physically and economically. While liquid-cooling imposes higher costs upfront, air-cooling levies a performance and efficiency tax, so to speak, that can increase the total cost of ownership for an air-cooled 1-GW facility within a few years of operation.

The most important reason is the 'thermal wall': air-cooling can remove at best around 40 kW per rack. However, modern artificial intelligence (AI) chips like the Nvidia Blackwell generate 700-1,000 W per GPU, so a rack could emit around 120-150 kW. At this scale, air-cooling the racks will require them to be installed inside a wind tunnel, with the power consumption skyrocketing.

Air-cooling will also demand acoustic control as the number of fans and chillers required will create large amounts of noise.

In fact, air-cooling chillers and air-handling units can produce up to 100 dB, and if the resulting low-frequency hum is not quickly dampened, it can travel several kilometres if atmospheric conditions are also favourable, disturbing the sleep of people in the way. For this mix of pros and cons, many 1-GW data centres today use hybrid cooling: air-cooling for low-density servers and other areas, rear-door heat-exchangers to push air-cooling to remove up to 50 kW, and direct-to-chip (DTC) liquid-cooling for high-density AI clusters, including the Nvidia Blackwell.

What have Google and TCS committed to?

After concerns were raised about the water demands of the Google hyperscaler data centre, Visakhapatnam MP M. Sribharat said, "Google has confirmed it will use air-cooling technology... there is no question of impact to water supply."

The tech giant has also said it will replenish 120% of water consumed for non-cooling needs across its operations by 2030, quantified under the Volumetric Water Benefit Accounting standard. *Hindustan Times* also quoted Alexander Smith, principal of Global Infrastructure and Energy, Asia Pacific, Google, as saying "Google is also planning integrated watershed-management measures, including rainwater catchment systems on data-centre buildings, groundwater recharge infrastructure, water pumps, and water ATMs".

Likewise, *Mint* quoted HyperVault CEO Deepesh Kiran Nanda saying, "We are building infrastructure for where AI is going: higher density, liquid cooling, larger power blocks, and faster deployment". Per news agency ANI, the HyperVault will also feature DTC cooling as well as use renewable energy.

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THE DAILY QUIZ

Following the 'Correct the Map' resolution adopted by the UN last week, a quiz on maps and geography

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

Which African country sponsored the resolution for the 'Equal Earth projection', and which was the lone nation to vote against the resolution, as against 164 supporting the same?

QUESTION 2

What is the scientific study of maps called and which entity is the principal agency in India responsible for all national map publications?

QUESTION 3

What is the name given to the network of latitude and longitude lines drawn on a map or globe?

QUESTION 4

The Prime Meridian passes through five African countries. Two of them are Togo and Ghana. Name the other three.

QUESTION 5

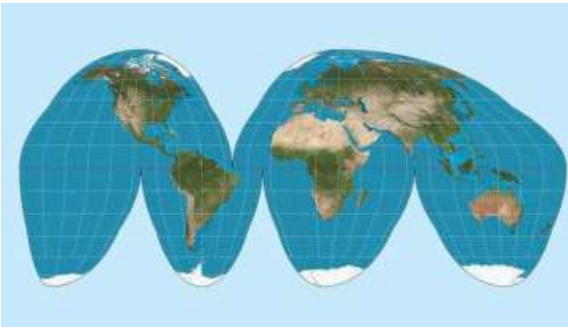
What remote point in the South Pacific, formally called the oceanic pole of inaccessibility, is farther from land than any other location in the world's oceans?

QUESTION 6

Map-makers sometimes use 'trap streets' (or 'fake towns') while designing maps. What are they?

QUESTION 7

Why is the term 'atlas' used for a book containing maps?



Visual question:

What is the term used for this projection of the world, where it is deliberately broken into lobes, giving it an appearance sometimes compared to an orange peel? WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Childhood - Public speaker - Pune ashram - Arrival in the United States - 1984 bioterror attack. **Ans: Osho (Rajneesh)** 2. Early life - Mathematics career - Life in Montana - Mail bombings - Manifesto. **Ans: Ted Kaczynski, aka the Unabomber**

3. Early life - Founding a blood-testing startup - Self-made female billionaire - Downfall - Fraud charges. **Ans: Elizabeth Holmes, founder of Theranos** 4. Early life - Career - Photography hobby - Later years - Death - Discovery and recognition - Legacy. **Ans: Vivian Maier, American street photographer** 5. Early religious and political influences -

Founding a new religious organisation - Relocation to South American country - Mass murder-suicide. **Ans: Jim Jones**

6. Early life - Led her own gang - Massacre - Surrender - Political career - Assassination. **Ans: Phoolan Devi** Visual: Identify the African leader and fill in the blank. Early life - Rise in Army - Seizure of power - Expulsion of _____ - War with Tanzania - Exile - Death - Erratic behaviour, self-bestowed titles and media portrayal. **Ans: Idi Amin; Ugandan Asians** **Early Birds:** Sekar S. | A.C. Vineeth Kumar | Piyali Tuli | Aryan Wari | Siddhartha Viswanathan



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of "fly by night" operators? (M.K.B. Nambiar, Mahe)

Every month we read in the papers that the manager of some chit fund company has disappeared with the hard-earned money of his clients.

Such people can be called fly by night operators. They set up a company, do roaring business for about six months and then they suddenly disappear. They are there one day and then perform the disappearing act overnight.

The word "fly" in the expression means to "flee", that is, to run away. Since the shady characters who run such businesses leave town during the dead of night when everyone else is sound asleep, they are called "fly by night operators". All this build-up should have given you a fairly good idea as to what the expression means.

It means "undependable, dishonest". The expression can be used with people as well as with organisations.

There are many fly by night characters staying in that hotel.

Did you know that you could refer to a person as "fly"? When you say that someone is "fly", it means he/she is very knowledgeable about something. This use of the word "fly" is considered slang. So do not use it in formal contexts.

Amrit is fly, there's no doubt about it. The word also means "stylish, nice-looking".

Some of the girls think that the present Vice Chancellor is really fly.

What is the collective noun for tigers? (G. V. Chalapathi Rao, Nellore)

Tigers are solitary animals; therefore, there is no specific collective noun to refer to them. Here are some interesting ones, however: pride of lions, school of fish, pod of whales, gaggle of geese, and rag of colts.

How is the word "pandemonium" pronounced? (M. Venkatesan, Srivaikuntam)

This is a word that many people in our country have begun to associate with Parliament sessions. The first syllable is pronounced like the word "pan", while the "e" in the second syllable and the "u" in the final syllable are pronounced like the "a" in "China". The "mon" rhymes with "bone", "phone", and "cone". The "i" in the fourth syllable is like the "i" in "it", "bit", and "fit". The main stress is on the third syllable, "mon". Any idea what the word means? When there is pandemonium, there is usually a lot of shouting and screaming because people are angry or frightened about something.

What is the difference between "leave" and "holiday"? (P. Maheswari, Venkatagiri)

A "leave" is something that you take on your own; it is something that you apply for and when it is granted, you are allowed to be away from work for some time.

The word "holiday" comes from "holy day"; originally, it was a day of rest from work for everyone. Nowadays, there's nothing holy about a holiday. If you say that tomorrow is a holiday, what you are saying is that everyone, not just you, is getting the day off. Unlike "leave" one needn't apply for "holiday". *Published in The Hindu on November 20, 2001*

Word of the day

Alacrity:

liveliness and eagerness

Synonyms: willingness, enthusiasm, goodwill, swiftness

Usage: *The team welcomed the news with alacrity.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/alacrity

International Phonetic

Alphabet: /əˈlækrəti/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

EC announces byelections to six seats on October 6

Two Assembly constituencies in T.N., two in Bengal, one in Puducherry, and a Lok Sabha seat in Assam are going to the polls; focus on Rejinagar and high-profile Nandigram, vacated by Suvendu

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission on Monday announced that byelections in five Assembly constituencies in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Puducherry, and one Lok Sabha constituency in Assam would be held on October 6.

The nomination process will remain open until September 16, and counting will be held on October 9. The election process would be completed by October 11.

The byelections were necessitated following the resignations of elected legislators across the three States and the Union Territory for various reasons.

In Tamil Nadu, vacancies arose in Madurantakam (SC) and Dharapuram (SC) following the resignations of Maragatham Kumaravel and P. Sathyabama, respectively. Ms. Kumara-



A file photo shows people waiting to exercise their franchise in the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls in Chennai in April. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

vel and Ms. Sathyabama both had been elected on AIADMK ticket in the 2026 Assembly polls and resigned to join Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam.

In Puducherry, the Thattanchavady constituency opened up after the resignation of N. Rangasamy. The Chief Minister had won from both Thattanchavady and Mangalam seats and decided to give up the former.

In West Bengal, Rejinagar and the high-profile Nandigram are up for election following the resignations of Humayun Kabir and Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, respectively. Mr. Adhikari decided to retain the Bhabanipur seat, where he had defeated then incumbent Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

Offered to Mamata
Mr. Kabir, a former Trinamool Congress leader who

floated the AJUP after his expulsion from the party, won from both Nowda and Rejinagar and decided to retain the former. He has offered the Rejinagar seat to Ms. Banerjee to contest. It remains to be seen whether Ms. Banerjee will choose either Nandigram or Rejinagar to make a return to the Assembly.

In Assam, the Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency is going to the polls following the resignation of Pradyut Bordoloi. He had won on Congress ticket in 2024. He subsequently joined the BJP and won from Dispur in the Assembly polls.

Two other Lok Sabha seats—Shillong in Meghalaya and Basirhat in West Bengal – remain vacant, and polls have not been scheduled there yet.

The Model Code of Conduct will come into effect immediately in the districts encompassing the poll-bound constituencies, the EC said in a statement.

Rahul seeks accountability for Delhi building collapse

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing the BJP government of evading accountability for the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday targeted Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying Mr. Modi puts labels such as “dimagi Naxal” (intellectual Naxal) and “naraaz phooph” (angry uncle) on anyone who asks questions.

“There is no accountability,” Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X, asking what explained the “helplessness” of a “triple engine” government in Delhi.

The lack of action stemmed from a “lack of intent”, Mr. Gandhi alleged, adding that the government followed a “shameful pattern” of taking no preventive action before accidents, followed by grandstanding and attempts to fix responsibility on lower-level officials after tragedies.

“The collapse of the building packed with students at Satya Niketan is no



Rahul Gandhi

isolated tragedy,” he said, referring to six deaths in a building collapse in Saidulajab and 22 deaths in a fire in Hauz Rani in the last four months. Those demanding accountability were instead being “shamed, defamed and silenced”.

‘Four-engine govt.’

At a press conference, Congress leader Kanhaiya Kumar, accompanied by National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) president Vinod Jhakhar, stepped up the attack, calling the BJP’s “four-engine government” in Delhi a “killing machine”.

Mr. Kumar pointed out that apart from the Union

and Delhi governments, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi was also controlled by the BJP and the Lieutenant-Governor with executive powers was appointed by the Centre. He also questioned the Prime Minister’s absence from the site, pointing out that Mr. Modi had addressed students at Delhi University’s Shri Ram College of Commerce on Saturday. “Narendra Modi went to SRCC for his PR, so why didn’t he go to Satya Niketan?” Mr. Kumar asked.

The Congress demanded inspection of all paying guest accommodations, construction of hostels within Delhi University, a rent control law for hostels and paying guest accommodations, and compensation of at least ₹1 crore to each bereaved family.

Party leader Abhishek Dutt alleged that the scrapping of Section 466(A) of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act through the Jan Vishwas Act had weakened criminal action against builders undertaking illegal or dangerous construction.

Inflation puts festive cheer under strain, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday said rising prices of essential commodities had put a strain on household budgets ahead of the festive season, and accused the Union government of resorting to “statistical jugglery” instead of containing inflation.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said inflation’s “high-voltage shock” was weighing on the joys of festivals, with prices of several food items rising sharply. “Wholesale prices of onions have doubled in just three weeks. Sugar has risen by 25%,” Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X. Prices of arhar, urad, mustard and refined oil had also increased, while almonds, cashews, pistachios, raisins and walnuts had become costlier ahead of Deepavali, he said.

“Statistical jugglery cannot hide the impact of inflation. The public is watching everything,” he said.

13 lakh voters deleted from Delhi’s electoral rolls in pre-SIR phase

Suruchi Kumari
Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Pooja Devi, 38, has been living at the same address in Kalkaji for the past two decades, employed in domestic work. When the special intensive revision of electoral rolls began in the national capital in June, however, she did not get any enumeration form. Once the draft roll was published, she hoped to find her name in the list of those removed because they were absent, shifted, dead, or with duplicate names, but her name was missing there too.

“My husband and children received their forms but I did not. I had also voted in the 2025 polls with them. My name is nowhere,” she said, flummoxed by the booth-level officer’s claim that no form was generated in her name.

Ms. Devi seems to be among the 13.39 lakh voters whose names were deleted from the electoral roll in Delhi this year, even before the SIR process started in June, according to *The Hindu’s* analysis of data available on the website of Delhi’s Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

At the time of Assembly elections in February 2025, Delhi’s electorate stood at 1.56 crore. By June 16 this

year, when the electoral roll was frozen before the SIR started, this had dropped to 1.45 crore, a decrease of 11.01 lakh names.

After the SIR started, a further 47.56 lakh names have been deleted in the draft roll published on August 31, meaning that so far, 37.6% or well over a third of the voters in the roll during the 2025 Assembly polls are no longer part of Delhi’s electorate.

Delhi CEO Ashok Kumar and his office did not respond to *The Hindu’s* queries, including whether notices were served on those whose names were deleted during the pre-SIR mapping exercise.

According to the Election Commission’s rules, continuous updation of the electoral roll happens through individual applications for new enrolments or objections, with BLO field verification required in cases of unregistered deaths and shifting of voters, only after receiving Form-7. In all such cases, a notice must be issued. The Electoral Registration Officer can also take up deletions, corrections, or shifting of names *suo motu*, based on the BLO’s field report. There is no draft roll or claims and objections period for such routine updating exercises, unlike for special revisions.

Rahul Gandhi interviews candidates for AICC posts

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday interviewed several party workers as the party’s high command looks to appoint new All India Congress Committee (AICC) secretaries.

Though the exact number of candidates is not known, sources said that 30 to 40 people were interviewed in separate batches.

The move is part of the high command’s attempt to bring in new faces and give representation to Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes.

AICC secretaries are attached to general secretaries handling different States and departments.

India’s carbon credit scheme receives U.K. recognition: official

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

In a major breakthrough, the U.K. has recognised India’s Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) as a qualifying criterion for pricing relief under its carbon border adjustment mechanism (CBAM), a move that would reduce the tax burden on domestic exporters, an official said on Monday.

In a communication addressed to the Bureau of Energy Efficiency, Ministry of Power, the U.K.’s His Majesty’s Treasury confirmed that the CCTS has been included in the U.K.’s published indicative list of overseas carbon pricing schemes assessed as qualifying criteria under a provision of the Carbon Bor-



The recognition is expected to reduce tax burden on Indian exporters. GETTY IMAGES

der Adjustment Mechanism (Calculation of CBAM Rate and Determination of Carbon Price Relief) Regulations 2026, the official said.

“This will reduce the effective CBAM liability on Indian goods, directly benefiting Indian exporters,” the official said.

Gujarat to host National Film Awards for first time

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The National Film Awards ceremony will take place in Gujarat for the first time on September 22, with the 72nd edition scheduled in Ekta Nagar. President Droupadi Murmu will present the awards, government officials said on Monday.

The move to Ekta Nagar marks a departure from the awards’ traditional venue in Delhi. The first National Film Awards ceremony was organised here in 1954, and Delhi has hosted most of the subsequent ceremonies. The Awards have been presented outside Delhi before – the 17th and 18th editions were held in Madras (now Chennai) in 1970 and 1971, as per reports.

The winners of the 72nd National Film Awards, announced in July, include *Article 370* as the best feature film. Yami Gautam has been named as the best actress for the same film. Mammootty and Kartik Aaryan will share the best actor award for their performances in *Bramayugam* (Malayalam) and *Chandu Champion* (Hindi) respectively.

Randeep Hooda has won the best debut director award for *Swatantrya Veer Savarkar*.

Quota will put more women in political leadership: Om Birla

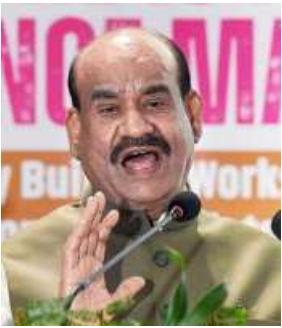
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday said the proposed 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies would open new avenues for women’s political leadership, stressing that the role of women must move beyond receiving support, to shaping policies and laws.

Inaugurating a two-day all-India capacity building workshop on gender-responsive governance”, organised by the National Commission for Women (NCW), in Faridabad, Mr. Birla said the day was not far when women would account for more than 50% of those in public services.

The focus should shift from merely providing women with support and opportunities to enabling them to actively determine policies, programmes, and legislation addressing their concerns and aspirations, he said.

Women legislators in Parliament, Assemblies, panchayats and municipalities could play a decisive



Lok Sabha Speaker addresses participants at a workshop in Faridabad on Monday. ANI

role in ensuring that laws reflected ground-level realities. Institutions such as the NCW also had an important role in identifying emerging challenges and facilitating solutions.

India could not achieve the goal of becoming a developed nation without the economic and social empowerment of women, who constitute nearly half the population, he said.

He also urged women legislators to share successful initiatives and strengthen awareness among women, especially those in vulnerable sections, about laws and institutional mechanisms available to address their concerns.

Congress SC, ST MPs to petition President over ‘purification’ row

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Thirty-two Congress MPs belonging to the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities on Monday decided to petition President Droupadi Murmu over the alleged “purification yajna” held in Uttarakhand’s Haldwani following a rally addressed by party president Mallikarjun Kharge.

In a meeting at the Congress headquarters, the MPs described the incident as a grave assault on the dignity and self-respect of SCs and STs and a direct af-

front to the constitutional values of equality and abolition of untouchability.

“We discussed the shocking purification incident in Haldwani following Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge’s rally. We have decided to form a parliamentary forum to fight this at all levels. We will be submitting a representation to the President of India on Tuesday,” Lok Sabha member Mallu Ravi said.

The MPs finalised a memorandum seeking the President’s intervention and appropriate action. They also decided to con-

stitute a parliamentary forum to take up issues concerning SC and ST communities.

Congress leaders K. Raju and Rajendra Pal Gautam also attended the meeting. Mr. Raju said the proposed forum would discuss a strategy for raising issues concerning SCs and STs in Parliament.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi had condemned the incident that happened on August 11 and demanded an FIR be registered under the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act against those responsible.

**MAHATRANSCO**
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

NOTICE INVITING TENDER CPD/41-2026-27

Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:

Tender No. & Description of Material	Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs)	Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
	Tender Fee (in Rs.)	
SP/T-0509/0926 RFx 5000001604 (3rd Call) for Procurement of 420kV, 2x80MVA Switchable Line Reactor along with New Uninhibited Naphthenic Based High Grade Mineral Insulating Oil required for 400kV Kumbhargaoon Sub-Station	3378.39	15.09.2026 17:00 Hrs.
	25,000.00	15.09.2026 17:15 Hrs.
Pre-Bid Meeting:	Date: 08.09.2026 Time: 16:30 Hrs.	Venue: 8th Floor, MSETCL, "Prakashganga", BKC, Bandra (E), Mumbai

Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (Gr-V) CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai
Tel. No.: 022-69852717/69852720
Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eegrp5@mahatransco.in
For further details visit our website <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>
Any further amendments/clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>.
Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (P&C)

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Office of the Chief Engineer
TENDER NOTICE
ADV No.30/D3/CE/TTD/2026-27, NIT No.426 /SE-II/TTD/ 2026 -27 dt:06-09-2026
Name of work:1) Laying of additional MS Pipe Line from Gogarbhram Dam to Filter plants at main Filter House, Tirumala. **Amount Rs.600 Lakhs,Time for Completion:12 months.**
NOTE: For full details, log on to the Website <https://www.tirumala.org>.
TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.175) Date:07-09-2026
EXECUTIVE OFFICER

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER
PSWC invites online tenders through GeM Portal for creation of 1.45 LMT godown capacities at 04 locations in the State of Punjab for guaranteed lease of 10 years on Build, Own and Operate/Lease basis for storage requirements of FCI under two bid system "Technical Bid" and "Financial Bid".
NIT (alongwith GeM Bid IDs) is available on Department's website i.e. <https://pswc.in>
PSWC reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and PSWC will not be held liable for any costs and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.
Note: Any corrigendum(s)/Notification(s) to this Notice Inviting E-Tender shall be published Department's website & GeM Portal.
1004/12/2026-27/14913
Managing Director, PSWC

A ND-NDE

INBRIEF



RBL Bank to raise up to \$1 bn from overseas investors

Private lender RBL Bank on Monday said its board approved the mobilisation of up to \$1 billion from overseas investors through bond issuance. The board approved the establishment of a Euro Medium Term Note Programme (EMTN Programme) in accordance with Regulation S of the US Securities Act, 1933, subject to regulatory, statutory and other approvals, RBL Bank said in a stock exchange filing.

Govt. spurs coal rake loading by 20% to strengthen stock

Loading of coal rakes for supply to the power sector has grown about 20% between September 3 and 6, the Union Coal Ministry said on Monday, adding that it was also closely monitoring thermal plants with stocks below 25% of their normal requirements with measures being taken to ease their supply position. According to data from the Central Electricity Authority, 53 domestic coal-fired plants were operating at the critical normative level as on September 5.

Copper prices head to record high; tight supplies outside U.S.

Copper prices headed toward a record high on Monday, as the prospect of shortages outside the U.S. spurred buying, while the softer dollar reinforced positive sentiment. Traders said that a U.S. holiday meant volumes were likely to be muted, but added that focus was firmly on copper and zinc. Benchmark copper on the London Metal Exchange was up 0.1% at \$14,430 a metric tonne at 0931 GMT, the highest since the all-time peak of \$14,527.50 hit in January.

In a first, alternative fuel vehicles outsell petrol cars in India

CNG, hybrid and electric together overtook petrol in the PV market at 41.95% against the latter's 40.85% in August 2026, FADA data showed

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Indian automobile industry retailed 24,23,201 units in August 2026, registering a 17.51% growth year on year (YoY).

However, compared with July 2026, retail sales fell by 6.48% due to the lull in seasonal monsoon and a festival calendar that shifted Ganesh Chaturthi and the spillover of Onam-led buying into September.

Growth was led by Wheeled Construction Equipment at 31.45%, Two-wheelers 19.69%, Passenger Vehicles 16.14%, and Commercial Vehicles 14.45%, while Three-wheelers grew 8.64% and Tractors sales were effectively flat at 0.84%, as per data released by the Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (FADA), Monday.

For the first time in India, alternative fuels – CNG, hybrid and electric combined – overtook petrol in the passenger vehicle (PV) market, at 41.95% against petrol's 40.85%.

“Two-wheelers, passenger vehicles, commercial vehicles, tractors and three-wheelers each set fresh August records, and overall registrations were the highest ever for the month,” said Sai Giridhar, president, FADA.

Two-wheeler retail sales

Ethanol effect

An analysis of automobile retail sales data shows beyond the volume record, fuel mix has reached an inflection point

CNG vehicle sales stood at 25.28%, Hybrids 9.04%, and EVs 7.63%

Electric CV share rose to an all-time high of 5.18% from 2.06% a year ago



Dealers attribute shift to running-cost economics, consumer hesitation around E20 transition

stood at 17,14,610 units, up 19.69% YoY – the best August since 2018 – but down 5.70% MoM.

Share of e-TWs crossed the 10% mark (10.68%) in a non-festival month for the first time, against 7.66% a year earlier.

Commercial vehicle retails came in at 90,769 units, up 14.45% YoY – the best-ever August – though 8.93% lower MoM.

LCVs grew 15.32% YoY, HCVs 13.98% and MCVs 10.38%, with dealers citing infrastructure execution, mining and e-commerce-linked logistics alongside steady financing.

Electric CV share rose to an all-time high of 5.18% from 2.06% a year ago, with e-CV volumes setting a fresh monthly record.

Passenger vehicles retailed at 4,02,398 units, up 16.14% YoY. For the first time, the PV segment has crossed the four-lakh mark in an August though MoM

sales was lower at 3.40%.

Beyond the volume record, the fuel mix reached an inflection point – alternative fuel vehicles (CNG 25.28%, Hybrid 9.04%, EV 7.63%) together touched 41.95%, surpassing petrol vehicles (40.85%) for the first time, though petrol remains the single largest individual fuel.

“Dealers attribute the shift to running-cost economics and continuing consumer hesitation around the E20 transition, nudging petrol buyers towards CNG, hybrids and EVs,” Mr. Giridhar said.

PV inventory rose by a further five days over July-end to about 38-40 days, well above FADA's recommended 21-day benchmark, with 56% of PV dealers reporting higher stock MoM, he added.

With three-wheeler EV penetration at 65.30% – the segment is now structurally electric.

JLR to slash 4,000 jobs worldwide in 2 years to save £1.7 bn

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Jaguar Land Rover (JLR), a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Limited (TMPV), has announced reduction of its global workforce by about 4,000 roles over the next two years as part of a “strategic transformation programme.”

“The reduction, which is not expected to impact direct manufacturing jobs, will be achieved through voluntary means wherever possible,” TMPV said in an exchange filing. “JLR is today beginning consultation on the first round of reductions and will provide support to all colleagues affected by the changes and engage with Trade Unions and employee representatives throughout the transition,” it added in the statement.

“We recognise this will be difficult news for colleagues affected, and are committed to supporting everyone with care, fairness and respect,” JLR CEO P.B. Balaji said in a statement.

JLR said that the “strategic transformation programme” was designed to “simplify the organisation, improve operational performance and support long-term sustainable growth.”

“As per JLR's “Growth Reimagined” strategy announced at its Investor Day on 19 June 2026, JLR is targeting approximately £1.7 billion of savings over the next two years to reduce its break-

The reduction is not expected to impact direct manufacturing jobs, according to the company

evens towards 3,00,000 units,” the company said.

The savings, it said, were designed to enhance JLR's ability to deliver sustainable profitable growth, against the backdrop of an increasingly competitive and rapidly changing market and continuing geopolitical uncertainty.

“The programme will reduce organisational complexity, and underpin the commitment to invest between £15-18 billion in electrification, digital technologies, advanced manufacturing and enhanced customer experiences over the next five years,” Mr. Balaji said.

“The automotive industry faces significant challenges, with technological change amidst intense competition and ongoing geo-political uncertainty. Through our Growth Reimagined strategy, JLR is moving decisively to strengthen our competitiveness and position the business for long-term success,” he said.

Over the next 12 months, the company will launch five new products, continue to leverage the strength of its brands, and renew its focus on North America, amongst other markets, to help it deliver double digit revenue growth, he stated.

RBI mops up ₹6 lakh crore in 2 auctions with mixed response

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday mopped up over ₹6 lakh crore of excess funds from the banking system in two auctions, which saw an underwhelming response from banks despite surplus liquidity.

The 30-day variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction announced last week received a tepid response from banks, and the central bank announced another auction in the first half of the day.

As against ₹7 lakh crore of notified amount, the first auction received a tepid response, with bids of just over ₹2.59 lakh crore being received for the 30-day VRRR, according to an official statement.

The bids for the 30-day VRRR were accepted at the cut-off and weighted average rate of 5.24%, according to the RBI. Soon afterwards, the RBI announced an overnight VRRR auction with a notified amount of ₹5 lakh crore, which was completed at 11:30 hrs.

Market response to the second auction was a tad better, with bids of ₹3,53,390 crore received, which amounts to over 70% of the notified amount, indicating that lenders are comfortable parking funds for a shorter tenure. For the overnight, the RBI accepted the full amount at a cut-off rate and weighted average rate of 5.24%.

There are large inconsistencies between GDP and other economic indicators: says Garg

Kunal Shankar
Santosh V. Perumal

Former Finance Secretary Subhash Chandra Garg has questioned the credibility of India's latest GDP estimates. In an email response to *The Hindu*, he argued the sharp downward revisions to the size of the economy need a far more transparent explanation than the government's invocation of a new methodology, wider coverage and improved data.

At the centre of his concern is the absence of a transparent bridge between the 2011-12 base series and 2022-23 series. Mr. Garg said MoSPI must publish a back-series from 2011-12 to 2021-22 and set a timetable for doing so. “Perfectly valid demand,” he said, arguing absence of such a programme suggested that the government was “not very serious” about resolving the issue.

He was particularly concerned about the reduction in the estimated nomi-



Subhash Chandra Garg

nal size of the economy. The revision in Q1 FY26, he said, was part of a much larger change with GDP for 2024-25 reduced by ₹12.70 lakh crore. The Centre did not adequately explain why the revisions resulted in a smaller economy.

The standard explanation – new series incorporates wider coverage, new data sources and indices – was, in his view, insufficient. “Any better coverage leads to nominal GDP getting increased, not decreased,” he reasoned.

Mr. Garg offered two

possibilities for the revisions: the earlier system overstated GDP on errors such as double counting or the GDP was deliberately overstated to produce stronger growth numbers, and later, written down under the cover of the new series. He gave no evidence of deliberate manipulation but said the scale of the revision made essential a detailed explanation.

He also questioned the price architecture underpinning the latest real-growth estimate. With consumer inflation over 4% and producer-price inflation about 9%, he said, the about 2.5% GDP deflator implied by the latest numbers appeared difficult to reconcile. “There is definitely a serious internal inconsistency,” he said, calling for the underlying price data to be disclosed and explained.

Mr. Garg was equally sceptical of the application of double deflation to manufacturing, arguing international best practices can-

not simply be transplanted without sufficiently granular Indian data. Until the new methodology stabilises, he suggested the older system be run in parallel.

His concerns extend beyond methodology to the independence of the statistical system. India's data infrastructure needs “massive modernisation,” he said, but the statistical system could still produce reliable numbers if there was no “political interest to produce results in a certain direction.” Statisticians needed greater freedom from political control.

No statistical noise

The broader problem, Mr. Garg argued, was the divergence between GDP and other indicators of economic well-being. Weakness in household incomes, employment, consumption and sentiment cannot always be dismissed as statistical noise, he said, particularly when particular data outcomes turn politically sensitive.

GDP itself, he stressed, was not a measure of welfare. India does not adequately publish the “income leg” of national accounts showing how value added is divided between labour, corporations and government. With per-capita GDP still low, he argued India must target 9-10% growth while redistributing income more effectively and reducing unproductive government expenditure.

For Mr. Garg, the government's technical responses have therefore failed to close the credibility gap. Its explanation for the reduction in GDP, he said, remained “officialese, obfuscatory” and “sheds no light.”

He was unequivocal about the central issue: the downward revision in GDP was real and, in his assessment, must ultimately be explained either by an earlier overstatement or by acknowledging earlier growth was artificially inflated. “Nothing can falsify my argument,” he said.

‘50% of Indian firms say macro growth isn’t fully translating’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Half of Indian businesses reported the country's strong macroeconomic performance either has not translated into improved business performance or has done so partially, as per the latest Confederation of Indian Industry's (CII) Business Outlook Survey.

This finding comes at a time when questions have been raised about whether the Centre's GDP growth numbers are reflective of the ground situation.

However, the composite business confidence score in the CII Business Outlook Survey for July-September 2026, looking at the current situation as well as future expectations, rose to 66 in Q2 from 60.8 in the first quarter of FY27. The score in Q2 of this year was the same as in Q2 last year.

“The sharp improvement reflects strengthening in business sentiments, primarily supported by the easing of disruptions stem-



A sizeable number of firms saw higher demand.

ming from the West Asia conflict,” the survey stated.

The survey covered 238 public sector and private firms from “all industry sectors”, including micro, small, medium and large enterprises, from different regions, the CII said.

The data shows 13.4% of the respondents said “on ground conditions were subdued despite strong macro data” while 36.6% said they saw some improvement in business conditions “but weaker than indicators suggest”.

However, 11.3% of the respondents said business growth “matches or ex-

ceeds macro momentum”.

Another 29.4% said they saw “clear benefits, though somewhat below headline growth”. The survey does not mention how the balance 9.3% voted.

The demand aspect of the survey showed 29.4% of the respondents expect no change in local demand in Q2 vis a vis Q1. Also, another 3.5% expect demand to be more than 20% lower than in Q1 while 6.1% expect demand to be 5-20% lower than in Q1.

The other side of this data is a sizeable number of firms saw higher demand.

“For Q2FY27, 61% of respondents expect demand to rise, while only 9.6% foresee a moderation, a widening of the positive margin over Q1 that signals sustained confidence in end-market conditions,” the survey showed.

“The share expecting demand growth above 20% rises from 12.9% in Q1FY27 to 16% in Q2FY27, indicating that optimism is not just holding but intensifying at the upper end.”

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA - DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER,
MURAN DAM DIVISION, KHATIGUDA
AT/PO-KHATIGUDA, DIST-NABARANGPUR, PIN-764085
E-mail I.D.: emurandamddivision@gmail.com

PAPER PUBLICATION NOTICE
e-Tender Call Notice No.: EEMDD-04(04)/2026-27, Dated:-29.08.2026

2. Name of the Work Civil Works
3. No. of Works 01 (One) Number
4. Estimated Cost Rs.-1.80 Crore (e-TCN SL.No.4)
5. Eligibility of the bidders 'A' & 'B' Class contractors (Odisha P.W.D or equivalent class of other licensing authority) as per Detail Tender Call Notice.
6. Period of completion 04 (Four) Calendar Months
7. Date of Clarification 09.09.2026 to 11.09.2026 Only During Office Hour
8. Time for receipt of bid in the Portal From 09.09.2026 (11.00 AM) to 24.09.2026 (up to 5:00 P.M.)
9. Date & place of opening of the bids on-line 25.09.2026 (11:00 A.M)
10. Name and address of the Tender Inviting Authority (TIA) Executive Engineer, Muran Dam Division, Khatiguda, At/PO: Khatiguda, District: Nabarangpur, Pin-764085, Odisha

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "<http://tendersodisha.gov.in>"

Executive Engineer, Muran Dam Division, Khatiguda
32001/815/2627 OIPR-32001/32230/1/26-27/0003

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER & BASIN MANAGER,
SUBARNAREKHA & BUDHABALANGA BASIN,
AT/PO:- LAXMIPOSI, DIST:-MAYURBHANJ. Mail Id : cebmsbb2019@gmail.com
Government of Odisha "e" PROCUREMENT NOTICE
Bid Identification No.- 10/26-27 of CEBM, SBB, Laxmiposi

1	Name of Work	Irrigation Work
2	Total No. of Project	2 Nos.
3	Estimated Cost	Varies from Rs.504.21 Lakhs to Rs.504.28 Lakhs
4	Bid Security / E.M.D.	Details can be seen in the DTCN of bid documents of the respected works
5	Period of Completion	Details can be seen in the DTCN of bid documents of the respected works
6	Class of Contractor	"A" Class
7	Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal	07.09.2026 at 10.00 AM
8	Last date / time for receipt of bid in the portal	24.09.2026 up to 5.00 PM
9	Date of opening of bid	25.09.2026 at 11:00 A.M.
10	Name & Address of the O.I.T.	Chief Engineer & Basin Manager, O/o the CE&BM, Subarnarekha & Budhabalanga Basin, Laxmiposi, Mayurbhanj.

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement Portal "<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>" .

Chief Engineer & Basin Manager,
Subarnarekha & Budhabalanga Basin, Laxmiposi, Mayurbhanj
32001/820/2627 OIPR-32001/32074/1/26-27/0004

SRM E-Tender Notice (3rd Call)

Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Company Ltd, EHV PC O&M Zone Vashi invites bids through SRM E-Tender in two bid system (Techno-commercial Bid & Price Bid) from the eligible registered bidders for following works;

RFx No./ Tender No.	Particulars	Estimated Cost
7000041425 T-10/2026-27 (3rd Call)	Work of enhancement of existing corridor of 220kV Kalwa-Mulund-Bhandup-Borivali Line by addition of LILO cable at 220kV Bhandup GIS Substation for Mumbai strengthening under EHV O&M Division Kalwa	Rs. 2060.30 Lakhs excluding GST Rs. 2431.15 Lakhs including GST

E.M.D. in Rs. 20,60,302/-, Tender Fees: Rs. 29,500/- including GST, Sale period: 07.09.2026 to 17.09.2026, Last Date of Submission: 17.09.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs, Date of opening (Tech. bid): 17.09.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. (if possible).

Contact person: Executive Engineer, EHV PC O&M Zone, Vashi, Phone No. (022) 27666010 (P)/27665994.

For further details please visit to <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in>

Sd/-
Chief Engineer
EHV PC (O&M), Zone, MSETCL, Vashi

NUUK

EU announces funding boost for Greenland as Trump seeks control



European Union chief Ursula von der Leyen unveiled plans on Monday for \$232 million of EU investments in Greenland, which President Donald Trump has insisted should belong to the U.S. “The EU stands in full solidarity with the Kingdom of Denmark and the people of Greenland,” Ms. von der Leyen said. REUTERS

JERUSALEM

Israel threatens ‘full-scale war’ on PA in case of October 7-style attack



Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz has threatened a “full-scale war” against the Palestinian Authority (PA) if it prepared an attack against Israeli forces or settlements similar to the one launched by Hamas from Gaza on October 7, 2023. The remarks came after a stabbing attack in the northern occupied West Bank. AFP

KATHMANDU

Nepal holds a day of mourning as rescuers focus on trapped workers



Nepal held a national day of mourning with candlelight vigils on Monday for victims of devastating glacial floods, as families of missing hydropower workers feared trapped in tunnels prayed rescuers might yet find them alive. The August 26 floods killed at least 1,399 people, with more than 5,500 missing. AFP

BELGRADE

Thousands turn out in Serbia for funeral of convicted war criminal



Bosnian Serb war criminal Ratko Mladic was buried in Belgrade on Monday, in a service attended by thousands, sparking accusations from European Union of the “glorification” of a man who died while serving a life sentence for genocide. Despite his conviction, Serb nationalists continue to paint Mladic as a hero and protector. AFP

U.S. energy facilities in Gulf remain exposed to retaliation, warns Iran

Tehran issues threat after latest clashes with the U.S.; new Hormuz passage maps to be approved soon, ships entering new restricted zone will be added to sanctions list, says Iran’s security head; oil prices near six-week highs after attacks on ships

Reuters
DUBAI

Iran threatened on Monday to retaliate against any new U.S. attacks on its assets, warning that the energy production chain in the region was “sprawling, accessible and exposed” and that U.S. oil and gas companies there shared that exposure.

“Strike our assets and you get struck,” Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said after U.S. and Iranian strikes on shipping at the weekend that pushed oil prices up to six-week highs at one point on Monday.

On Sunday, senior Ira-



Persian tides: People ride in a boat near vessels in the Gulf waters off the coast of Iran’s port city of Bandar Abbas on Monday. AFP

nian security official Mohsen Rezaei said Iran would announce plans for a new restricted zone in the Gulf in the coming days, and that it would soon approve maps of a new shipping

corridor through the Strait of Hormuz.

Mr. Rezaei said the new restricted zone would begin from where a U.S. naval blockade of Iran starts and extend into areas of the

Gulf. Any ship entering the new zone would be added to an Iranian sanctions list, he said. “We will only commit to the Strait of Hormuz being open when they (the Americans) stop the sabotage, threats and attacks on Iran,” Mr. Rezaei said.

Underlining Iran’s defiance, Mr. Qalibaf issued a new threat to respond to any U.S. strikes, in what appeared to be a response to a warning by U.S. Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth that Iran’s oil tanker fleet was “defenceless”.

“It’s simple: the oil and gas production chain here is sprawling, accessible, and exposed. American oil and gas companies across these waters and facilities

share that exposure,” Mr. Qalibaf, who is Iran’s top negotiator, wrote on X.

Meanwhile, Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei on Monday warned South Korea against military deployment or involvement in U.S. operations in the Strait of Hormuz, saying such a move would have “serious consequences”.

On Friday, Seoul said it was considering “contributions” to U.S. security efforts in the Strait of Hormuz. South Korea said it would consider the move provided that its own military readiness was not compromised, but added that no decision had been made.

German far-right AfD wins big in State poll, falls short of majority

Reuters
BERLIN

The Alternative for Germany (AfD) appealed on Monday to lawmakers from Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s conservatives to support its bid to rule Saxony-Anhalt after the far-right party surged into first place in the eastern German State’s election.

The AfD won 43.8% of the vote, official results showed. However, the party fell a little short of winning a majority in its quest to form the country’s first far-right State government since the Second World War. The party has won 39 of the 83 seats in the State legislature, and hopes to win over individual conservative lawmakers.

The election result rais-

es serious questions about the longstanding refusal of Germany’s mainstream parties, including Mr. Merz’s Christian Democrats (CDU), to work with the AfD, a policy known as the “firewall”.

“Politics always means compromise,” AfD leader Tino Chrupalla said, appealing to CDU lawmakers to make a “centre-right conservative majority” in Saxony-Anhalt possible.

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Monday he was “deeply shocked” by his party’s State election defeat at the hands of the far-right AfD.

“This is the heaviest electoral defeat the (CDU party) has suffered in years, in decades,” Mr. Merz said. His party scored just 17.2% of the vote.



An eight-year-old Lebanese boy receives treatment in Nabatieh, after he was injured in the strike.

12 killed in Israeli strikes in southern Lebanon

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Israel conducted a wave of airstrikes in south Lebanon killing 12 people including women and children, the Lebanese Health Ministry said on Monday, in an intensification of violence after a weeks-long lull.

One of the overnight strikes hit a building in the town of Kfar Rumman, killing 11 people, including two children and four women. Another attack in the same town killed a rescuer and wounded another, according to the Ministry.

The Israeli military in a statement said it had struck Hezbollah “infrastructure sites” across southern Lebanon after the launch of two explosive drones towards its troops.

The Army said it “will continue to operate to remove threats while remaining committed to the ceasefire agreement”.

Hezbollah has not claimed any attack since June 20.

Israeli airstrikes and a ground invasion of Lebanon have killed more than 4,300 people since March, according to Beirut.

U.K. govt. slams anti-migrant protests

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

The U.K. government condemned protests by hundreds of people in Portsmouth, who had gathered until the early hours of Monday morning to protest the arrival of illegal migrants on a dinghy from France. Protesters faced off with police, as they sought to block buses carrying migrants for processing in Kent.

“We condemn the intimidating and thuggish behaviour we saw in Portsmouth last night,” a Home Office spokesperson said in a statement emailed to *The Hindu* and other news organisations.



A migrant tries to board a dinghy from France in an attempt to cross the English Channel.

The words were echoed by government Ministers. The way the protesters behaved “crosses a line”, Treasury Secretary Emma Reynolds said. Police and Crime Com-

missioner for Hampshire and the Isle of White, Donna Jones, who is affiliated to the Conservative Party, said 140 migrants arrived in one boat early on Sunday morning from France.

The Home Office declined to comment on whether any of the migrants who had arrived were Indian nationals.

A day earlier, some 200 protesters took to the streets in the coastal port town of Dover, with visuals of masked men boarding trains and marching along the road chanting, “Whose streets? Our streets.”

Business Secretary Jonathan Reynolds said: “I condemn it. I mean, peaceful protest – essential part

of British life, but that’s not dressing up in costumes like this and disrupting people’s lives.”

Commissioner Jones said the U.K. government had “lost control” of the 100s of miles of British coastline in an interview with Sky News.

The number of protesters had grown to 400-500 by midnight on Sunday, and they stayed on till about 3 a.m. in Eastney, in Portsmouth, Ms. Jones said “when a legal position was agreed” and protesters agreed they had made their point. She said the incidents were a “real wake up call” for the U.K. government over the lack of border control.

King in the rubble



Palestinian children watch a screening of *The Lion King* at camps sheltering displaced people in Sheikh Radwan neighbourhood, north of Gaza City. X/PALESTINE_UN/OMAR ASHTAWY

+

Sport

Suruchi brimming with excitement ahead of maiden Asiad appearance

SHOOTING

Uthra Ganesan
BHOPAL

Suruchi Phogat first held a pistol in 2019, at the age of 13. She did so because there were no rifles at the Guru Dronacharya Shooting Academy in Bhiwani; and because her father was determined to make her a sports person.

The 20-year-old will be one of the favourites to medal for India in 10m air pistol at the Asian Games later this month, as much because of her performance streak over the past 18 months as her ability to keep things simple.

“Excitement. No ner-



Suruchi. R.V. MOORTHY

vousness, no challenge, nothing. There is only excitement inside me because it is my first Asian Games,” she said, a permanent wide smile on her

face exuding an openness that only accentuates her clarity of thought.

The ‘baby’ of the Indian shooting contingent, Suruchi insisted that everyone was equal in the squad but admitted that certain members of the coaching and sports science staff are slightly more protective, telling her what to do and expect while travelling.

It is a throwback to the time she took the local trains for a 100-km journey from Sasroli village in Jhajjar district of Haryana to the academy.

“My father and brother accompanied me. At that time, of course no one knew but once the results and medals started coming, the regulars on the

train would recognise me.

“They would say they had seen my face in the local newspapers and be curious. I would tell them that I am a shooter.

“It’s not like I suddenly became famous or anything but yes, it was the beginning of a realisation that I am doing something,” she laughed.

Eventful journey

Making the cut for Aichi-Nagoya has been an eventful journey that has seen her win four consecutive World Cups and the World Cup Final, set a National record in 10m air pistol and a World junior record in the process and rise to World No. 3. It is only the beginning.

Priyanka upbeat despite the challenge

ATHLETICS

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Tempted by the prospect of winning a prize, Priyanka Goswami ventured into race walking.

As a young gymnast at the K.D. Singh Babu Stadium Sports Hostel in Lucknow, Priyanka found that she had a flair for track and field.

After taking the big leap of faith, her first test came at a district athletics meet.

“We used to get a bag as a prize at the meet. I tried a few running events, but I could not do well. I did not get even a single bag,” Priyanka said at a media interaction facilitated by the Sports Authority of India here.

Priyanka then noticed



Aiming high: Race walker Priyanka wants to finish on the podium at the Asian Games. K. MURALI KUMAR

that her chances of winning a bag were substantially higher in another event. “There were only three girls in the race walking event. I figured that I could defeat at least one of them,” she said with a laugh.

Priyanka finished third, won her bag and, in the

process, embarked on a new career path.

“As a gymnast, my body was flexible and my technique was good. From there, God took me all the way to the Olympics,” she said, referring to her appearances at the 2020 Tokyo and 2024 Paris Games. In 2022, Priyanka made

history, winning silver, winning silver to become the first Indian woman to clinch a race walking medal at CWG

history, winning silver to become the first Indian woman to clinch a race walking medal at the Commonwealth Games.

Priyanka fell just short of another medal at the recent 2026 Commonwealth Games, where a time penalty saw her finish fourth.

The 30-year-old is confident about her chances at the upcoming Asian Games, where the competition from Japan and China pose a mighty challenge.

“It is true that race walking is dominated by Japan and China. If I can get a medal, it will be a big achievement in my life,” Priyanka said.

LEARNING CURVE

The captaincy process leads to immense personal growth: Kishan



R. RAGU

When you are the captain, the first thing is situational awareness, you have to stay alert the entire day on the field to understand what is happening and what isn't. Going through this whole process leads to immense personal growth, and while you might not realise it immediately, your mindset shifts completely — Ishan Kishan.

TEAM FIRST

‘When you are the skipper, it becomes a duty to help players’



R. RAGU

There are many small things we often overlook in our daily routines. You don't look at your players or try to help them figure out how they can get better. But when you are the skipper, it becomes your duty to help them, because if your teammates are improving, ultimately you will achieve the team's goals — Ishan Kishan.

SMOOTH START

Maaya storms into second round of junior singles at New York



FILE PHOTO

Maaya Rajeshwaran outclassed Emery Combs of USA 6-2, 6-2 in the first round of the girls singles at the US Open. The 15th-seeded Indian will take on Arina Malygina in the second round. In the doubles event, Maaya and Antonina Sushkova will meet the American duo of Combs and Olivia De Los Reyes in the first round.

‘SPECIAL MENTOR’

Pietersen joins England coaching team ahead of World Cup



FILE PHOTO

Kevin Pietersen has joined England's white-ball coaching team as a “specialist mentor” in the build-up to next year's World Cup in southern Africa. The former England captain will be part of Brendon McCullum's coaching group for the upcoming T20 and ODI series at home to Sri Lanka later this month, as well as subsequent series.



A thorn in the flesh: Kishan made the South bowlers toil for a second successive day. R. RAGU

Kishan puts South under the pump

The southpaw's blistering double century takes East past the 700-run mark; Kushagra joins the party with a hundred against a hapless attack

DULEEP TROPHY FINAL

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Ishan Kishan has been on a rollercoaster ride over the last few years. From being part of all three formats in 2023, he hit rock bottom by early 2024 when he was dropped from the BCCI central contract list, partly for his refusal to turn up for the Ranji Trophy.

Since then, the Jharkhand wicketkeeper-batter has been making amends, putting in the hard yards in domestic cricket to forge his way back into India's T20 and ODI squads.

Now, the 28-year-old is showing that he is ready to do the same in the longest format as well. He hammered 270 (334b, 30x4, 7x6) for East Zone against South Zone on day two of the Duleep Trophy final at the MAC Stadium on Monday.

Resuming at 385 for four, East posted a gargantuan total of 708 with Kumar Kushagra (101, 132b,

8x4, 5x6) completing his century. Kishan and Kushagra added 230 for the fifth wicket, pummelling a hapless South attack into submission.

Kishan set the tone with a brace of boundaries off Mohammed Siraj and M.D. Nidheesh. Kushagra soon joined in the act, lofting C.V. Milind and driving Nidheesh down the ground. He raced through his 90s by taking on Shreyas Gopal and brought up his hundred.

South's only hope of staging a comeback was with the second new ball, but Siraj, who bowled just three overs in his first spell, was off-colour yet again.

Post lunch, Kishan tore into Shreyas, smashing the leggie for three boundaries in an over. What stood out in the captain's knock was the way he shunned risks even when he used his feet, often drilling the ball past the bowler all along the ground. He raised his second First Class double century with a searing cover drive off Devdutt Padikkal. After the milestone,

Kishan switched to T20 mode and unleashed a barrage of sixes, lofting spinners Shreyas and T. Vijay with disdain. He needed just 30 more deliveries to raise his bat again – for a 250 – despite battling cramps.

Barring a miracle over the last three days, Kishan has ensured East has one hand on its third Duleep Trophy title.

The scores: East Zone — 1st innings: Abhimanyu Easwaran run out 72, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c sub (Tanay) b Milind 44, Shikhar Mohan b Milind 85, Sudip Kumar Gharani c Milind b Vijay 6, Ishan Kishan c Smaran b Vijay 270, Kumar Kushagra c Milind b Vijay 101, Anukul Roy lbw b Rasheed 45, Md. Kounain Quraishi c Siraj b Shreyas 40, Mohammed Shami b Shreyas 28, Abhijit Sarkar (not out) 0, Mukesh Kumar c & b Vijay 0; Extras (b-8, lb-2, nb-6, w-1): 17; Total (in 163 overs): 708.

Fall of wickets: 1-100, 2-133, 3-147, 4-241, 5-471, 6-626, 7-680, 8-698, 9-708.

South Zone bowling: Siraj 25-3-140-0, Nidheesh 15-2-58-0, Vijay 42-4-180-4, Milind 21-2-88-2, Shreyas 42-7-165-2, Rasheed 13-0-46-1, Padikkal 4-0-18-0, Bhui 1-0-3-0.

‘Captaincy has helped me become a better batter’

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

One of the hardest tasks for an international cricketer is how they respond to being dropped from the national squad and fight their way back.

And over the last year, Ishan Kishan has shown the way to do it.

“Sometimes, when we play regularly for the Indian team, you just keep playing in a flow. You may be a very good player, which is why you're playing for India, but your growth stagnates at a certain point.

“When you take one step back and go back to



Kishan... in full flow. R. RAGU

domestic cricket, you start from zero again,” said Kishan after smashing 270 for East Zone against South in the Duleep Trophy final

here on Monday.

“You start thinking, ‘I need to get even better,’ because today, there are so many players scoring runs. To get back into the team, your only option is to perform much better than them.

“You get time to reflect on what you missed earlier, why you couldn't convert your starts into big scores. I mean, the batting doesn't change that much; it's just the mindset that changes over time.”

Last year, Kishan led Jharkhand to a convincing Syed Mushtaq Ali title triumph and felt that captaincy had helped him become a better batter.

Alcaraz crushes Paul, runs into Shelton in quarterfinal

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Defending champion Carlos Alcaraz posted his most convincing win in his injury return at the US Open, downing Tommy Paul in straight sets on Sunday to line up a quarterfinal clash with Ben Shelton.

Second-seeded Alcaraz looked closer to his brilliant best in a 6-4, 6-3, 6-4 victory over Paul, the 20th seed. Alcaraz will face red-hot Shelton, a 6-2, 6-3, 6-4 winner over Stefanos Tsitsipas, for a place in the semifinals.

In the women's section, Linda Noskova reached the quarterfinals, edging Ukraine's Marta Kostyuk in three sets. The Czech, who has largely flown under the radar in New York despite winning Wimbledon, beat

THE RESULTS

Men: Fourth round: 2-Alcaraz (Esp) bt 20-Paul (USA) 6-4, 6-3, 6-4; Michelsen (USA) bt 27-Etcheverry (Arg) 7-6(6), 6-4, 6-4; 11-Tiafoe (USA) bt 7-Medvedev 7-6(1), 6-4, 7-6(6); 8-Shelton (USA) bt Tsitsipas (Gre) 6-2, 6-3, 6-4.

Women: Fourth round: 5-Andreeva bt 24-Potapova (Aut) 5-7, 6-4, 6-3; Zheng (Chn) bt 8-Swiatek (Pol) 7-5, 6-3; 6-Noskova (Cze) bt 11-Kostyuk (Ukr) 7-5, 5-7, 6-4; 3-Pegula (USA) bt 16-Cirstea (Rou) 6-3, 6-4; 26-Navarro (USA) bt 21-Kalinskaya 6-4, 6-2.

Kostyuk 7-5, 5-7, 6-4, finally sealing the win on her sixth match point when Kostyuk netted a backhand return.

“I am more than relieved,” Noskova said after booking a last-eight showdown with defending champion Aryna Sabalenka.

American Frances Tiafoe, the 11th seed, booked

his quarterfinal berth with a 7-6(1), 6-4, 7-6(6) victory over former champion Daniil Medvedev. Tiafoe will face compatriot Alex Michelsen, who defeated Argentina's Tomas Martin Etcheverry 7-6(6), 6-4, 6-4, for a place in the semifinals.

Women's third seed Jessica Pegula, one of the players with a chance to supplant Sabalenka atop the rankings in New York, reached the last eight with a 6-3, 6-4 victory over Romanian Sorana Cirstea.

On Monday, Paris Olympics gold medallist Zheng Qinwen, who had to come through qualifying, stunned six-time Grand Slam champion Iga Swiatek 7-5, 6-3 to reach the quarterfinals.

Fifth-seeded French Open champion Mirra Andreeva beat Anastasia Potapova 5-7, 6-4, 6-3 to seal a last-eight berth.



Stroll in the park: Shelton proved too good for Tsitsipas. AP

Knights beat Pipers despite Anand's loss

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Viswanathan Anand rarely plays these days: he is more of a mentor and now the interim president of FIDE. Magnus Carlsen, who dethroned Anand as the World champion in 2013, has relinquished his crown.

Still, when the two all-time greats come across a chessboard, there is a buzz. That was quite palpable at the Lalit Ashok on Monday. They played some interesting chess too, on the third day of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, but Anand was unlucky, as he lost on time from an equal position. The five-time World champion, however, could afford to forget his defeat, as his team, PBG Alaskan Knights, won the match against Alpine APL Pipers 9-7. That, in fact, was the first loss in the tournament for Carlsen's team after winning both their matches.

A little later, however, the defending champion bounced back, scoring a crushing 15-3 win against Fyers American Gambits. Carlsen was held to a draw by Javokhir Sindarov, but K. Humpy, Vidit Gujrathi and Volodar Murzin won their

games, with black pieces, to ensure that their team would score heavily.

The Pipers top the table after four rounds. It has nine match points, and 43 game points. As many as four teams are on six points – Mumbai Masters (36 game points), American Gambits (34), Alaskan Knights (30) and Ganges Grandmasters (28). Two-time champion Triveni Continental Kings, which finally managed a victory, has three points.

The results: PBG Alaskan Knights bt Alpine APL Pipers 9-7 (Anand lost to Carlsen; Arjun drew with Anish; Yagiz Kaan bt Vidit; Lagno drew with Divya; Batsiashvili bt Humpy; Abhimanyu drew with Murzin).

Cheq Mumbai Masters bt Ganges Grandmasters 12-3 (Vachier-Lagrave drew with Nepomniachtch; Pranesh bt Aronian; Mamedyarov drew with Dominguez Perez; Harika drew with Shuvalova; Yip bt Tsolakidou; Abhimanyu bt Daneshvar).

Fyers American Gambits lost to Alpine Pipers 3-15 (Sindarov drew with Carlsen; Nihal drew with Anish; Dubov lost to Vidit; Bibisara drew with Divya; Sarasadat lost to Humpy; Maurizzi lost to Murzin).

Triveni Continental Kings bt Alaskan Knights 11-6 (Firouzja drew with Anand; Yi bt Arjun; Aravindh bt Yagiz Kaan; Jiner lost to Lagno; Kosteniuk bt Batsiashvili; Pranav drew with Abhimanyu).



Clash of titans: Anand was involved in an interesting game with Carlsen before losing on time. SUDHAKARA JAIN



Carlsen. FILE PHOTO: ALLEN EGENUSE J.

Chess in India is massive, says Carlsen

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Ahead of the Global Chess League, Magnus Carlsen had joked about how his team, Alpine APL Pipers, had done during his absence last year and hoped that it would not do worse this time. He should be pleased now.

Pipers have gone top of the table despite Carlsen not being at his best so far.

He has won only one of his four games – against his old rival Viswanathan Anand, and that too on time – but his teammates K. Humpy and Vidit Gujrathi have been doing rather well.

The two Indians are, in fact, the best performing players in the league at the moment, both winning three of their games.

“The team is doing fantastic,” Carlsen said. “Three wins out of four is great. My performance has been a bit underwhelming, but since the team is doing well. I am happy. It is nice to see good crowds here. Chess in India is massive.”

INBRIEF



Abhinandh wins title in WTT Youth Contender

India's P. B. Abhinandh, the top seed, clinched the boys' u-19 singles title, defeating Damian Floro of Slovakia 11-5, 11-8, 11-9 in final of the WTT Youth Contender Tunis II on Sunday.

Champions League fixtures to honour Nepal flood victims

European football will pause before the 18 Champions League games this week to honour victims of flash floods and landslides in Nepal. "A moment of silence will be held and a banner will be displayed as a sign of solidarity and support ahead of all UEFA Champions League matches," the European football body said Monday. The banner will say: "You are not alone, Nepal."

The schedule: AEK Athens vs. LASK Linz; Club Brugge vs. Aston Villa (both at 10.15 p.m. on Tuesday); Borussia Dortmund vs. Villarreal; FC Porto vs. Manchester City; Lille vs. Real Betis; Real Madrid vs. Inter Milan (all at 12.30 a.m. on Wednesday). Barcelona vs. Feyenoord Rotterdam; VfB Stuttgart vs. Viking FK (both at 10.15 p.m. on Wednesday); Liverpool vs. Atletico Madrid; Napoli vs. Arsenal; Paris Saint-Germain vs. Slovan Bratislava; Sporting CP vs. Galatasaray (all at 12.30 a.m. on Thursday). Fenerbahce vs. AS Roma; PSV Eindhoven vs. Shakhtar Donetsk (both at 10.15 p.m. on Thursday); Bayern Munich vs. Bodo/Glimt; Como vs. RB Leipzig; Manchester United vs. Sabah FK; Slavia Prague vs. Lens (all at 12.30 a.m. on Friday). All times in IST.

Fiorentina sacks Grosso after just three games in charge

Fiorentina coach Fabio Grosso has been sacked after just three Serie A matches and as many defeats. Fiorentina has made a disastrous start to its Serie A campaign, having also struggled early last season before eventually avoiding relegation.

In a sporting crossover, Venkatesh and Sindarov play a game of chess

Sports Bureau

BENGALURU

Cricket met chess on Sunday night. Royal Challengers Bengaluru all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer, who has played for India in both short formats, took on the World No. 4 Javokhir Sindarov in a game of chess.

After the match against the Uzbek, played at RCB Bar & Cafe, Venkatesh said: "I got the opportunity to play with the world's No. 4 chess player. I managed to survive five minutes without losing."

Sindarov, who will challenge India's D. Gukesh for



Game-time: Sindarov and Venkatesh faced off on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the World championship this year, is in the city for the Global Chess League, in which he is playing for

Fyers American Gambits. He was joined by his teammates Daniil Dubov, Nihal Sarin, Bibisara Assaubayeva,

Sarasadat Khademalsharieh, and MarcAndria Maurizzi.

Venkatesh also spoke of Bengaluru's passion for multiple sports. "I've been to a lot of cities in the country, but the love for sports here is just amazing, and it goes well beyond cricket," he said.

"Whether it is football, athletics, chess, pickleball or paddle, people here take their sport seriously, both in playing and supporting it."

There was also an exchange of shirts between RCB and American Gambits.

Super-sub Gatti helps Juventus hold Milan

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse

ROME

Federico Gatti came off the bench and scored an injury-time equaliser as Juventus snatched a 1-1 draw with AC Milan in Serie A on Sunday.

Both teams arrived at the

Allianz Stadium after starting the season with back-to-back wins and remained unbeaten after a hard-fought affair.

Meanwhile, Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta said his side's performance in Sunday's statement 2-1 Premier League victory over Chelsea showed that it can become even better than

last season's title-winning model. Goals by Kai Havertz and Martin Odegaard, after Morgan Rogers had scored for Chelsea in the second minute, ensured a third win from three games for Arsenal. "It was an exceptional performance. I enjoyed every minute of it from the beginning to the end, and the beginning was tough," Arteta said.

The results: LaLiga: Alaves 5 (Boye 27, 51, 68, Mariano 36, Ibanez 90) bt Osasuna 2 (Budimir 46, 64-pen); Malaga 0 drew with Levante 0; Espanyol 1 (Fernandez 90+8) drew with Sevilla 1 (Stassin 85). **Serie A:** Bologna 2 (Piccoli 50, Dovbyk 90+1) drew with Sassuolo 2 (Doig 19, Adzic 56); Juventus 1 (Gatti 90+2) drew with AC Milan 1 (Cisse 68).

Nonpareil lives up to the billing in Khammam Plate

HYDERABAD: Trainer D. Netto's ward Nonpareil, ridden by Akshay Kumar, won the Khammam Plate, the chief event of Monday's (Sept. 7) races.

The winner is owned by Mr. Rajendran rep. Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP, M/s. Tripuranivenkata Aditya Chowdary & P. Ranga Raju. Akshay Kumar rode two more winners on the day.

1. CHAITANYA CHAKRAM PLATE (1,400M): CLASSY TOUCH (Neeraj Rawal) 1, French Lieutenant (Antony Raj) 2, Ashwa Jaffna (Gaurav) 3 and Evansville (P. Sai K) 4. 1-1/2, 4 3/4 and 1-1/2. Im, 25.78s. ₹15 (w), 11, 12 and 19 (p). SHP: 41, THP: 35, FP: 49, Q: 34, Tanala: 110. Favourite: Classy Touch. Owners: M/s. Narendra V. Shah, N. Shyam Sunder, Anil V. Poduval, Meher K. Sunderji & Suyash U. Dalvi.

Trainer: Neelesh Rawal. **2. KHAMMAM PLATE (1,800M):** NONPAREIL (Akshay Kumar) 1, Winfield (Antony Raj) 2, N R I Superpower (D.S. Deora) and Get Lucky (Md. Ekram) 4. 1-1/4, 3 and 2-3/4. Im, 51.20s. ₹13 (w), 10, 10 and 21 (p). SHP: 18, THP: 37, FP: 19, Q: 16, Tanala: 67. Favourite: Nonpareil. Owners: Mr. Rajendran rep. Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP, M/s. Tripuranivenkata Aditya Chowdary & P. Ranga Raju. Trainer: D. Netto.

3. MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200M): ANNHILATOR (Akshay Kumar) 1, Knight Crusader (B.R. Kumar) 2, Glorious Power (M.S. Deora) 3 and Decoy (Shivam) 4. 2, 1/2 and 2. Im, 13.79s. ₹17 (w), 11, 19 and 33 (p). SHP: 27, THP: 81, FP: 38, Q: 27, Tanala: 664. Favourite: Annihilator. Owners: M/s. Srikanth

Badruka, Rama Seshu Eyunni & Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni. Trainer: D. Netto. **4. MANCHERIAL PLATE (1,600M):** HOPING HIGH (Mohit Singh) 1, Only My Way (Afroz K) 2, Sunny Day (P. Ajeeth K) 3 and Secret Option (Akshay K) 4. 2, Neck and 2. Im, 42.87s. ₹39 (w), 14, 12 and 10 (p). SHP: 103, THP: 52, FP: 666, Q: 477, Tanala: 1,451. Favourite: Sunny Day. Owner: Mr. Vipin Kalra. Trainer: Jasbir Singh. **5. BHADRACHALAM TROPHY (1,200M):** POLE STAR (Akshay Kumar) 1, Sharanga (Abhay Singh) 2, Flying Fury (G. Nares) 3 and Dubai Touch (M.S. Deora) 4. Not run: Colt Pistol. Neck, Neck and 2. Im, 13.74s. ₹20 (w), 15, 49 and 19 (p). SHP: 88, THP: 57, FP: 325, Q: 189, Tanala: 1,266. Favourite: Pole Star. Owners: Mr. Rajendran rep.

Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP., Mr. & Mrs. Shapoor P. Mistry rep. Manjiri Horse Breeders Farm Pvt. Ltd., & M/s. Ram H. Shroff & Raj H. Shroff rep. Stride Livestock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: A. Imran Khan.

6. MAHABUBNAGAR PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200M): HIGH SPEED DIVE (Rafique Sk.) 1, Ragnarök (Shivam) 2, Gloria (Antony Raj) 3 and Exclusive Black (Akshay K) 4. 4, Head and 1-1/2. Im, 12. 99s. ₹34 (w), 24, 13 and 10 (p). SHP: 38 THP: 44, FP: 84, Q: 49, Tanala: 341. Favourite: Ragnarök. Owner: Mr. Kothapally Phani Krishna. Trainer: B. Mukesh Kumar.

Jackpot: 70%: ₹6, 295 (77 tkts.) & 30%: 252 (823 tkts.) Mini Jackpot: 3,145 (21 tkts.). Treble: (i) 70 (483 tkts.), (ii) 656 (56 tkts.).



Encore beckons? This will be the Indian cricket team's second appearance at the Asian Games, having pocketed gold in 2023. FILE PHOTO

For cricket to grow, it has to be played everywhere: Gavaskar

The continental competition provides a unique opportunity for India's stars to mingle with athletes from other sports; the 77-year-old hopes that the Men in Blue savour the experience

ASIAN GAMES

Vivek Krishnan

In an unrelenting cricket calendar where monotony can set in over run-of-the-mill bilateral assignments, a multi-disciplinary event like the Asian Games holds the promise of a novel offering.

The competition provides a unique opportunity for India's high-profile cricketers to mingle with athletes from other sports whilst attempting to win gold for the nation. Shreyas Iyer & Co. will be looking to do just that when they travel to Japan for the continental spectacle's T20 tournament from September 24 to October 3.



Gavaskar. FILE PHOTO

This will be the Indian cricket team's second appearance at the Asian Games, having pocketed gold in Hangzhou, China, in 2023.

Sunil Gavaskar hopes the Men in Blue savour the experience of a multi-sport carnival. "You get to know

and talk to athletes from other sports, and get to know what makes them tick. It will be a wonderful experience," he said during a virtual media interaction.

Though reports have emerged of the arrangements in Japan for the cricketers not being up to scratch, Gavaskar emphasised that such obstacles shouldn't dissuade the game's stakeholders from exploring newer markets.

"If cricket has to become a global sport, it has to be played in different parts of the world. At the Olympics, for example, you could play in a city where cricket isn't generally played. You might not always get the best facilities," the 77-year-old opined.

"For the game to grow, I

would encourage them to play wherever possible."

If cricket is to pique the curiosity of spectators at the Asian Games, the boy wonder that is Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will have to show up. The spunky 15-year-old, who cracked two half-centuries against Zimbabwe after a baptism by fire against England, will hope to continue his upward flight.

"Look in T20 cricket, you can't expect consistency. Vaibhav is the kind of batter who can win you three or four out of 10 games. But he's somebody with whom we need to have patience," assessed Gavaskar.

(Watch cricket at Asian Games 2026 on Sony Sports and Sony LIV from September 17).

Arshi, Zidaan, Hridaan, Akshat drive to glory

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau

Nine-year-old Arshi Gupta continued her impressive run, securing maximum points in the Mini Max class in the fifth round, to win the MECO-FMSCI Indian National karting championship RMC India 2026 in Bengaluru on Sunday. Zidaan Arshaan Anees and Akshat Misra, both of Peregrine Racing, topped the Micro Max and Senior Max categories respectively. Hridaan Sanadhya of Crest Motorsports emerged winner in the Junior Max class.

Provisional results: Senior Max: Finals (17 laps): 1. Akshat Misra (Peregrine Racing) 15mins, 51.277secs, 2. Eshanth Vengatesan (MSPORT) 15:56.416, 3. Aahil Mecklai (Rayo Racing) 15:57.954. **Pre-Finals (14 laps):** 1. Akshat 13:11.439, 2. Rohaan Madesh

(Peregrine) 13:12.760, 3. Eshanth (13:13.459). **Best Rookie:** Eshanth.

Junior Max: Finals (16 laps): 1. Hridaan Sanadhya (Crest Motorsports) 14:58.444, 2. Rivaan Dev Preetham (MSPORT) 15:02.265, 3. Hamza Balasinarwala (Crest) 15:04.813.

Pre-Finals (14 laps): 1. Hridaan 13:12.488, 2. Swarnav Das (Crest) 13:15.148, 3. Rishik Rohit Reddy (MSPORT) 13:15.975. **Best Rookie:** Rivaan.

Mini Max: Finals (14 laps): 1. Arshi Gupta (Leapfrog Racing) 13:31.660, 2. Ridhaan Anil Kumarr (Red Rabbit Racing) 13:39.733, 3. Shivneel Karthikeyan (MSPORT) 13:39.854.

Pre-Finals (12 laps): 1. Arshi 11:34.763, 2. Ridhaan 11:41.565, 3. Shiv Tummala (Peregrine) 11:42.876. **Best Rookie:** Arshi.

Micro Max: Finals (12 laps): 1. Zidaan Arshaan Anees (Peregrine) 12:09.957, 2. Rudrapratap Singh Shekhawat (Leapfrog) 12:10.710, 3. Ayansh Patil (MSPORT) 12:14.196.

Pre-Finals (12 laps): 1. Zidaan 12:08.459, 2. Ayansh 12:08.797, 3. Rudrapratap 12:16.055. **Best Rookie:** Shriyan Rao Thakkallapelly (Peregrine).



Happy bunch: Young champs Hridaan, Arshi, Zidaan and Akshat.

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy (final): Day 3, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m. **Women's T20 Asia Cup:** Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m. **US Open:** SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m. & 4.30 a.m. (Wednesday) **Champions League:** Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 10.15 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Wednesday)



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R. Kaushik

The Cambridge Dictionary defines *introspection* as the *examination of and attention to your own ideas, thoughts, and feelings*.

Introspection must be a ruthlessly honest endeavour. It's not an exercise to impress others but to look inwards, reflect on what one is and what needs to be done to become the best version of oneself. It calls for taking ownership of one's actions, of accepting mistakes and errors, if any, and of zealously working towards eradicating those mistakes and making amends, if so required.

There is no better example in Indian cricket of the use of introspection as a self-betterment tool than Ishan Kishan, the pocket-sized dynamite who has embarked on a sensational journey of reinvention that has made him one of the hottest properties, if only in the white-ball ecosystem for the time being.

To say that, at the beginning of 2026, his international career was at a crossroads will be a mild understatement. The destructive left-hander had worked himself out of favour as he allowed frustration, if not petulance, to get the better of him.

Overlooked from all three international playing XIs in the interest of team requirements and balance despite having done little wrong, Kishan took a leave of absence midway through the tour of South Africa in 2023-24, citing the need for a mental reset.

In choppy waters

But when he refused to obey the dictates of the Board of Control for Cricket in India and made himself unavailable to play domestic cricket for Jharkhand despite practising for IPL 2024, which was imminent, he found himself in choppy waters. In an unequivocal warning, the BCCI stripped him of his central contract - as it did with current T20I captain Shreyas Iyer. The unsaid message was clear - don't take anything for granted.

Kishan had one of two paths to choose - wallow in self-pity, rail at the injustice of it all and allow himself to go to seed, or smell the coffee, accept that he had done himself no favours and wake up to the reality that if he aspired to represent the country again, he would have to not just produce the runs expected of him but to reiterate without any scope for doubt that he had learned his lesson.

The Jharkhandi did all that and more. He was outstanding in domestic cricket

across formats, not just batting with flair and keeping with assurance but also slipping effortlessly into the role of a leader. His tactical acumen revealed itself time and again, manifesting in a maiden domestic title - the 20-over Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy - last season with the captain himself starring in the final with a brazen century.

As India grappled with opening woes ahead of the home T20 World Cup, where they would be defending the title won in Bridgetown under Rohit Sharma in June 2024,

Kishan suddenly emerged as a very obvious and viable option. That the mandarins occupying the corridors of power had forgiven him became obvious when Suryakumar Yadav, the skipper, called up the younger man and asked him if he would win the team the World Cup.

Clearly, it wasn't a call Suryakumar made on his own. He would have consulted his bosses before approaching Kishan during a brief but very pithy chat. "*Chhotu, World Cup jitayega?*" the captain asked the wicketkeeper-batter, who responded with, "*Bharosa karogey?*" (Will you trust me?). Suryakumar's reply was instantaneous - "*Chal, kiya*" (Done). And just like that, Kishan was back in favour, back in business, back doing what he loves the most.

Celebrating the reintegration

Needless to say, Kishan kept up his end of the bargain. He celebrated his reintegration with international cricket with scores of 76, 28 and 103 in his second, third and fourth outings back, against New Zealand in India's final engagement before the World Cup. All these knocks came at No. 3, but with Sanju Samson suddenly blowing cold, he was thrust into the role of the opener-wicketkeeper at the World Cup, where he reeled off 20, 61, 77, 18 and 0 in the first five fixtures.

However, India were unable to get off to meaningful starts as opponents started to exploit the all-left opening salvo with off-spinners of varying quality.

Abhishek Sharma was in the middle of a horror run and therefore to break up the monotony of two left-handers, the think-tank took a punt on Samson, brought him back as opener and stumper and pushed Kishan down to No. 3 from the Super Eight fixture against Zimbabwe onwards. Samson came to the party with breathtaking knocks in the last three matches, including in the semis against England and the final against New Zealand, but Kishan didn't seem the drop

Listening to Kishan speak over the past few months is an eye-opening experience. One can see the deep impact of losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being

Kishan 2.0 – a sensational reinvention

Having made giant strides, the southpaw, who struck a double-hundred in the Duleep final, could not have asked for a better start to the First Class season



R.V. MOORTHY

to one-down with 38 (24b), 10 (6), 39 (18) and a whirlwind 25-ball 54 in the title clash.

Chhotu did help Suryakumar lift the World Cup, but while his fortunes have continued to be on the upswing, the man who created history by becoming the first to oversee a successful title-retention campaign was immediately dumped without so much as a thank you.

His T20I heroics have brought Kishan back into the ODI mix as well. In June, he marked his comeback with a frenetic 125, off a mere 79 deliveries, against Afghanistan in Lucknow, in what was just his second 50-over international in 32 months. By this time, he had led Sunrisers Hyderabad for the first half of IPL 2026, with regular skipper Pat Cummins travelling with the squad but not cleared to enter the fray by Cricket Australia.

Even though he knew that he was only keeping the seat warm for the Australian Test and ODI skipper, Kishan wasn't a stand-in captain in the strictest sense. He brought his tactical acumen and man-management skills into play, led from the front and left the team in a good space - and handily placed to make a charge for the playoffs - when the Aussie reassumed charge.

Cummins was quick at every opportunity to laud Kishan's leadership skills in his absence, their mutual respect apparent from the repeated discussions the nominated captain had with the man who had led in his absence when the two were reunited on the field of play for the second half of the season.

Distinct and stated desire

Kishan isn't merely content with white-ball laurels, though. At least among Indian batters, there is a distinct and stated desire to represent the country in

Test cricket. Tilak Varma, the gifted 23-year-old, said as much on the eve of the ongoing Duleep Trophy final, where he is leading South Zone against Kishan's East.

Tilak has made a name for himself as an exuberant, new-age T20 player, a reputation that has landed him the vice-captaincy of the national side, and it won't be long before he becomes a 50-over certainty too. But he is consumed by the ambition to play for the country in the five-day format.

Since debuting in the Ranji Trophy for Hyderabad when he was only 16 years old, the rangy left-hander has stacked up an average of 55.77 from 24 First Class matches. He has often been unable to represent his state in the red-ball game because invariably, India's players are involved in some T20 outing or the other during the Ranji Trophy, but it's only a matter of time before Tilak gatecrashes the Test side as well.

In that race, he has Kishan for company and competition. Obviously, the shorter man is considerably older than Tilak and has greater experience of first-class cricket - 66 matches before the Duleep final, an average of just under 40 and nine hundreds with a best of 273. Kishan's red-ball quest is anything but straightforward.

The effervescent Rishabh Pant is the designated wicketkeeper-batter who is relishing his second coming at the international level after a long break following his terrible car accident in December 2022, while Dhruv Jurel has stolen a significant march as the gloveman-in-waiting.

Jurel's Test debut came when Pant was recuperating from a series of surgeries, and he immediately caught the eye with his agility and compactness behind the sticks and his composure and technique

in front of it. In only his second Test, he steered the team to a tense victory in Ranchi in the company of current skipper Shubman Gill and has stacked up two centuries in his last seven Tests.

How highly he is rated by the leadership group is evidenced by the fact that he is in the Test XI as a specialist batter, occupying the No. 6 position so that he can split left-handers Pant and Ravindra Jadeja.

His last Test knock was a flowing unbeaten 115 in Colombo a fortnight back and even though he is widely regarded as a terrific player of spin, it is hard to see him being dislodged when India play their next Test, in seam-friendly Wellington in November.

Work cut out

Kishan knows therefore that he has his work cut out, but no one also knows better than him that hard work can take you places you had never imagined were accessible. His statement-making double-hundred in the Duleep final in Chepauk is exactly the kind of start to the domestic First Class season he would have envisaged, and one can rest assured that when he is not on India white-ball duty, he will torment bowlers whilst masterminding Jharkhand's fortunes in a leadership capacity.

Listening to Kishan speak over the last few months is a refreshing, eye-opening experience. One can see the deep impact of losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being who has still retained his innate impishness and the slant towards mischief. Clarity of thought is evident every time he opens his mouth, a clarity that is a spillover from his awareness in the middle.

In Ishan Kishan's fall from grace and his willingness to not just climb back on the horse but become a champion jockey again is a shining example of the wonders self-belief and commitment to the cause can catalyse. The intelligent young man is no longer chasing shadows or slaying inner demons. More power to him.

THE GIST

Kishan's T20I heroics have brought him back into the ODI mix. In June, he marked his comeback with a frenetic 125 against Afghanistan in Lucknow, in what was just his second 50-over international in 32 months

The southpaw isn't merely content with white-ball laurels, though. He knows that he has his work cut out, but no one knows better than him that hard work can take you places you had never imagined

In recent times, one can see the deep impact of the batter losing the central contract and finding himself in the dumps, but one can also easily make out that he has now become a more mature, grounded and realistic human being



R. RAGU



EMMANUAL YOGINI

S ND-NDE